

COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

MEDIEVAL HISTORY 04

THE KHALJIS: ALAUDDIN KHALJI & MARKET REFORMS

Source criticism + state-capacity framing | not a modern command economy | Delhi-centred military-fiscal system

Core problem

Mongol pressure, noble conspiracy and fiscal strain pushed Alauddin toward an unusually coercive but highly integrated military-fiscal regime.

Analytical chain

Revenue extraction -> grain supply -> regulated prices -> affordable cash-paid cavalry -> frontier defence and expansion.

Essential cautions

Barani is indispensable but not statistically neutral. Chittor is not Padmavat. Deccan campaigns mixed tribute, plunder and selective annexation.

Delhi core

Siri, market controls, pay discipline

North-west line

Forts, cavalry, frontier response

Expansion arc

Gujarat, Rajputana, Malwa, Deccan

Original deterministic cover visual for Topic 04. Schematic motifs only, not a map or a statistical chart.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Medieval History 04 - The Khaljis: Alauddin Khalji & Market Reforms - Complete Topic Package

Subject: Medieval Indian History | **Topic:** 04 | **Export date:** 2026-08-16 **Approval:** false - awaiting explicit user approval. **Source order:** repository Markdown -> local OCR-searchable Satish Chandra core and Part I Sultanate chapters -> local PYQ exports and routing ledgers -> no live official source was required for this export -> Qdrant not used. **Tag rule:** [FACT] source-grounded statement; [ANALYSIS] evidence-led synthesis; [DEBATE] historiographical disagreement or conceptual caution; [LIMIT] evidentiary, geographical or implementation qualification.

Package counts, provenance and honest limitations

- Learning sections: 24; learning MCQ loops: 16.
- Workbook content: 3 verified or honestly-adjacent PYQs; 32 original broad-coverage MCQs; 12 remedial MCQs; 6 original solved Mains questions; final register modules: 10.
- Original PNG visuals: 25 total - 24 body visuals plus 1 topic-specific cover visual. All maps are schematic and not to scale.
- Repository sources used most heavily: Topic 04 basic and advanced owners; bounded Topics 03, 05, 07 and 11; README.md; 00_Master-Chronology.md; REVISION-CHART_Ages-Eras-and-Distinctive-Features.md; ANSWER-WORTHINESS-AUDIT.md; Prelims and Mains PYQ routing ledgers; locally exported PYQ Markdown.
- OCR evidence used most heavily from Satish Chandra's *History of Medieval India* chapters on the Khaljis, Mongol threat, expansion, market reforms and culture, and from *Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part I* sections on the Mongol threat, internal restructuring, agrarian policy, state theory, cultural life and urban economy.
- [LIMIT] The market-control system is known above all through Ziauddin Barani and later synthesis. That makes the mechanism reportable, but not every number, speech or enforcement claim equally certain for every locality.
- [LIMIT] No direct UPSC PYQ was found locally on Alauddin's market reforms as a standalone question. The workbook therefore includes one direct routed Prelims question and two verified adjacent GS-I questions whose source, technology and state-capacity demands materially serve this topic.
- [LIMIT] Topic 04 owns Khalji political history, the military-fiscal reform complex, source criticism and bounded Khalji urban-architectural significance. Full Sultanate architecture ownership remains with Topic 11; full Bhakti-Sufi ownership remains with Topic 10; Vijayanagara-Bahmani and later Deccan state formation remain with Topic 09; Tughlaq consolidation and Deccan annexation beyond the Khalji horizon remain with Topic 05.

Sources actually used

Source class	Exact source	Use and caveat
Repository knowledge	Topic 04 basic and advanced owners; bounded Topics 03, 05, 07 and 11; Master Chronology; Revision Chart; official Medieval README; Answer-Worthiness Audit; PYQ ledgers and exports.	Controlled chronology, owner boundaries, terminology, source cautions, institutional comparisons and pre-existing corrected provenance such as dagh/chehra .
Local book	Satish Chandra, <i>History of Medieval India</i> , searchable OCR around printed pp. 86-105 and 184-185.	Foundation for Jalaluddin and Alauddin, Mongol crises, Gujarat-Rajasthan-Deccan campaigns, market and agrarian reforms, succession, and the Khalji architectural phase.
Local book	Satish Chandra, <i>Medieval India: From Sultanat to the Mughals, Part I</i> , searchable OCR around printed pp. 68-79, 73-79, 148-153, 272-273 and the cultural-life chapter.	Deeper control for the Mongol chronology, Barani caution, elite politics, agrarian intervention, market economy, state-shara debate, and historiographical framing.
Named primary traditions through source-critical synthesis	Ziauddin Barani (<i>Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi</i> , <i>Fatawa-i Jahandari</i>), Amir Khusrau (<i>Khaza'in-ul-Futuh</i> , <i>Tughluq-nama</i> and related courtly writing), Isami, inscriptions, monuments and coinage.	Used with genre caution. Barani is indispensable but late and normative; Khusrau is contemporary but court-praised and literary; Isami is displaced and retrospective; monuments and coins show durable claims but not full administrative reach.
Verified PYQ evidence	knowledge-export Mains and Prelims Markdown plus routing ledgers for 2022 Prelims, 2020 GS-I and 2023 GS-I.	Ensured exact wording or honestly limited wording verification. Prelims 2018-2023 key status remains locally unavailable, so inferred answers are explicitly labelled.
Live official or heritage source	None required for this export.	Local repository Markdown and OCR-searchable books were sufficient; no decorative current-affairs hook was forced.

Original visual asset index

- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/04_The-Khaljis-Alauddin-Khalji-Market-Reforms/00_khalji_cover_state_capacity.png
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- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/04_The-Khaljis-Alauddin-Khalji-Market-Reforms/08_north_india_vs_deccan_control_matrix.png

- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/04_The-Khaljis-Alauddin-Khalji-Market-Reforms/09_chittor_source_layer_matrix.png
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- notes/Medieval-Indian-History/assets/04_The-Khaljis-Alauddin-Khalji-Market-Reforms/24_gs1_answer_spine.png

PART I - Complete learning session

01. Scope, framing and chronology discipline

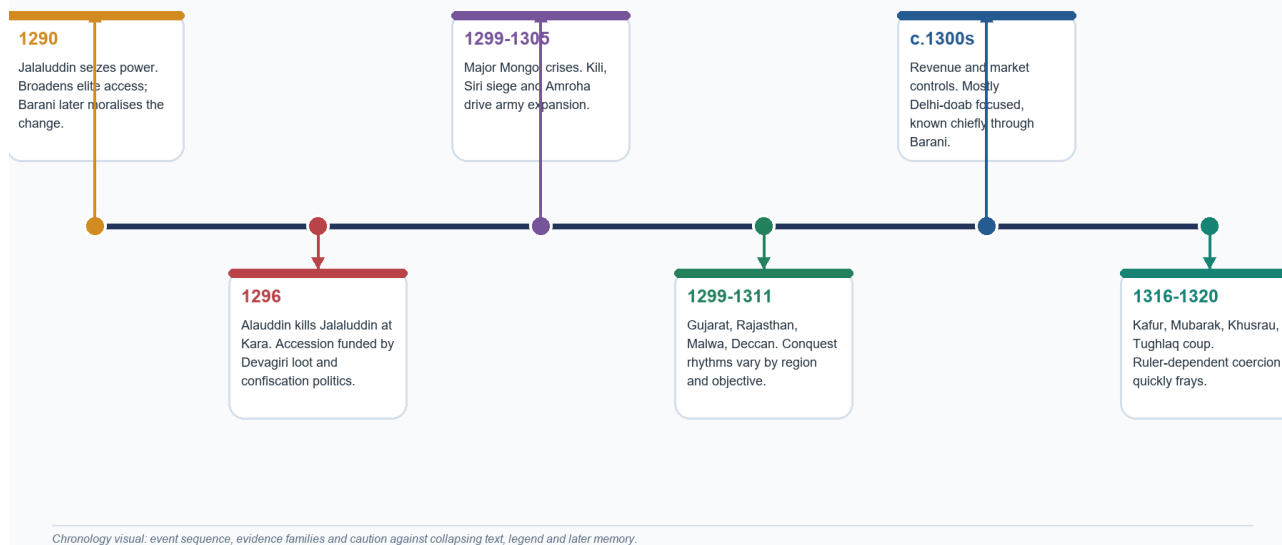
[FACT] Topic 04 begins from the **1290 Khalji accession** and runs to the **1320 Tughlaq takeover**.

[ANALYSIS] The best framing is **source criticism plus state-capacity analysis**. Alauddin Khalji's regime was neither a welfare price-control state nor a perfectly centralised modern command economy. It was a coercive, Delhi-centred **military-fiscal experiment** responding to frontier danger, elite conspiracy and imperial ambition.

[LIMIT] The same caution applies to opposite caricatures. "First socialist", "anti-Hindu fanatic", "proto-modern dictator", "uniform national market regulator" and "Padmavati's conqueror" are all exam-unsafe simplifications.

Khalji chronology and evidence spine

Rulers, turning points and main evidence families must be kept separate.

*01. Khalji chronology and evidence spine*

Chronology visual. It separates rulers, campaigns, reforms and evidence families so that source, event and later memory are never collapsed into one narrative.

Topic ownership firewall

Owner	What remains primarily there	What Topic 04 legitimately uses
Topic 03 - Mamluk dynasty	Balban, Mamluk institutional formation, frontier consolidation and the long decline of the Mamluk line	Only the transition needed to explain why Khalji accession mattered
Topic 05 - Tughlaqs	Ghiyasuddin, Muhammad bin Tughlaq, Firuz and the later Deccan annexation system	Only the immediate 1320 transition and comparison points where Khalji institutions are reversed or reworked
Topic 09 - Vijayanagara and Bahmani / Deccan politics	Independent post-1320 Deccan state formation	Only Khalji-era campaign reach, tribute logic and early openings
Topic 11 - Sultanate art and architecture	Full formal analysis of arches, domes, regional schools and stylistic evolution	Only bounded political meaning of Siri, Alai Darwaza, Alai Minar and Hauz-i-Alai
Topic 10 - Bhakti and Sufi movements	Spiritual movements in full	Only bounded references to Nizamuddin Auliya, Amir Hasan Sijzi or court-saint interaction where succession politics or cultural context require it

Governing thesis

- [ANALYSIS] The Khalji phase combined **wider recruitment to the ruling class, harder coercive monarchy, major northern and Deccan expansion**, and the most famous **revenue-market-army linkage** of the Sultanate.
- [ANALYSIS] Its success depended on making Delhi provisioned, cavalry affordable and nobles politically isolated.
- [LIMIT] Its institutions were impressive, but not equally deep everywhere. The most intense evidence concerns **Delhi and the upper doab**, not every province.

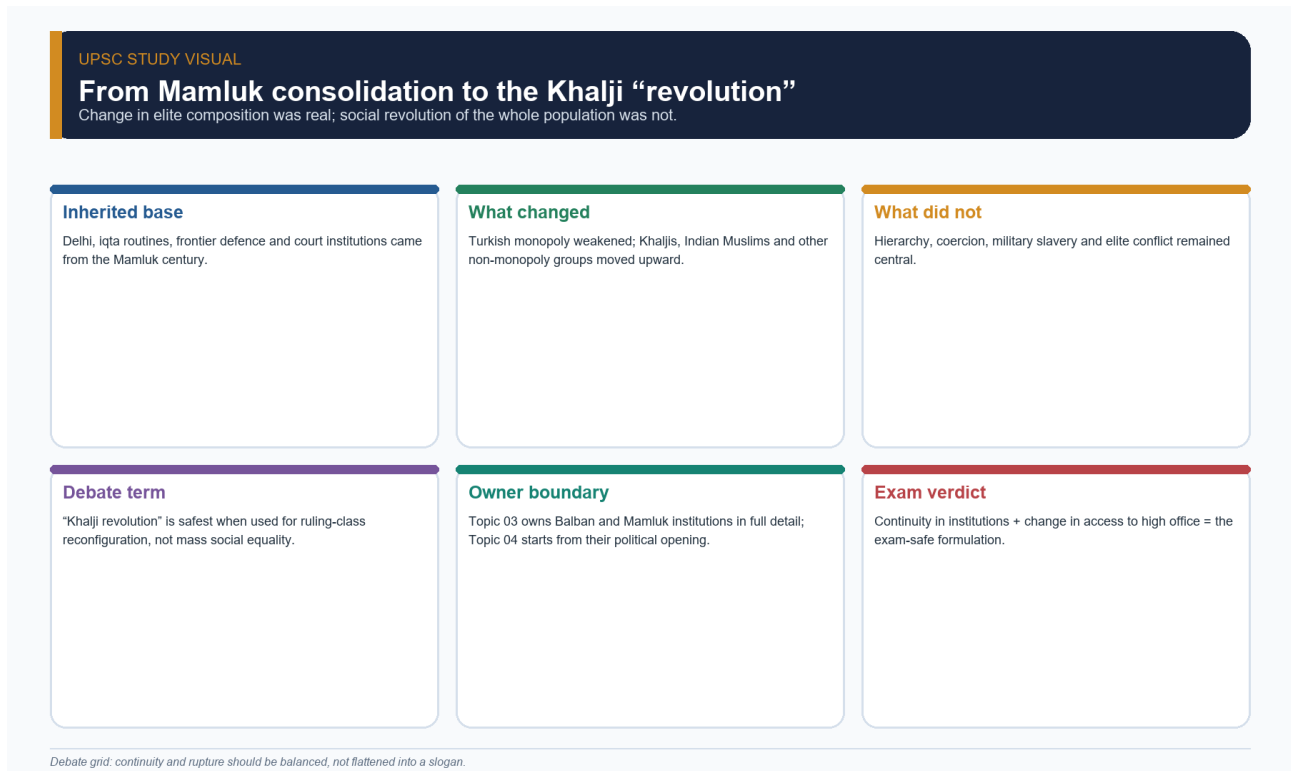
02. From Mamluk consolidation to the Khalji "revolution"

[FACT] The Mamluks left behind Delhi, iqta routines, coinage, court idiom and a frontier problem. They did **not** leave behind a stable succession or a permanently closed Turkish monopoly.

[FACT] Satish Chandra's concise OCR states that many **non-Turks**, including Khaljis and Indian Muslims, had long served in the Sultanate, especially in frontier and eastern spaces, but faced blocked advancement under old Turkish exclusivism.

[DEBATE] The phrase "**Khalji revolution**" is useful only if used carefully. It refers most safely to a **broadening of the social base of the ruling class** and the ending of the old Turkish monopoly of high office.

[LIMIT] It does **not** mean a social revolution among cultivators, artisans, women or the subcontinent's population at large.



02. Mamluk to Khalji revolution debate

Debate visual. It balances institutional continuity against elite-composition change and rejects mass-social-revolution overstatement.

Interpretation table

Interpretation	What it gets right	What must be resisted
Pure continuity	Khaljis inherited a functioning Delhi-centred state, frontier anxieties and iqta routines	It understates the change in who could rise to high office
Pure rupture	Khalji accession clearly broke old Turkish monopoly and widened elite access	It overstates total institutional novelty
Exam-safe synthesis	Mamluk institutions made Khalji expansion possible; Khalji accession widened access to power and intensified central coercion	Avoid both "nothing changed" and "everything changed"

Must-know distinctions

- [FACT] The Khaljis were described in the concise source as of **mixed Turkish-Afghan origin**.
- [FACT] They did **not** exclude Turks from office.
- [ANALYSIS] Their rise showed that the Delhi Sultanate was becoming more Indian in recruitment without becoming socially egalitarian.

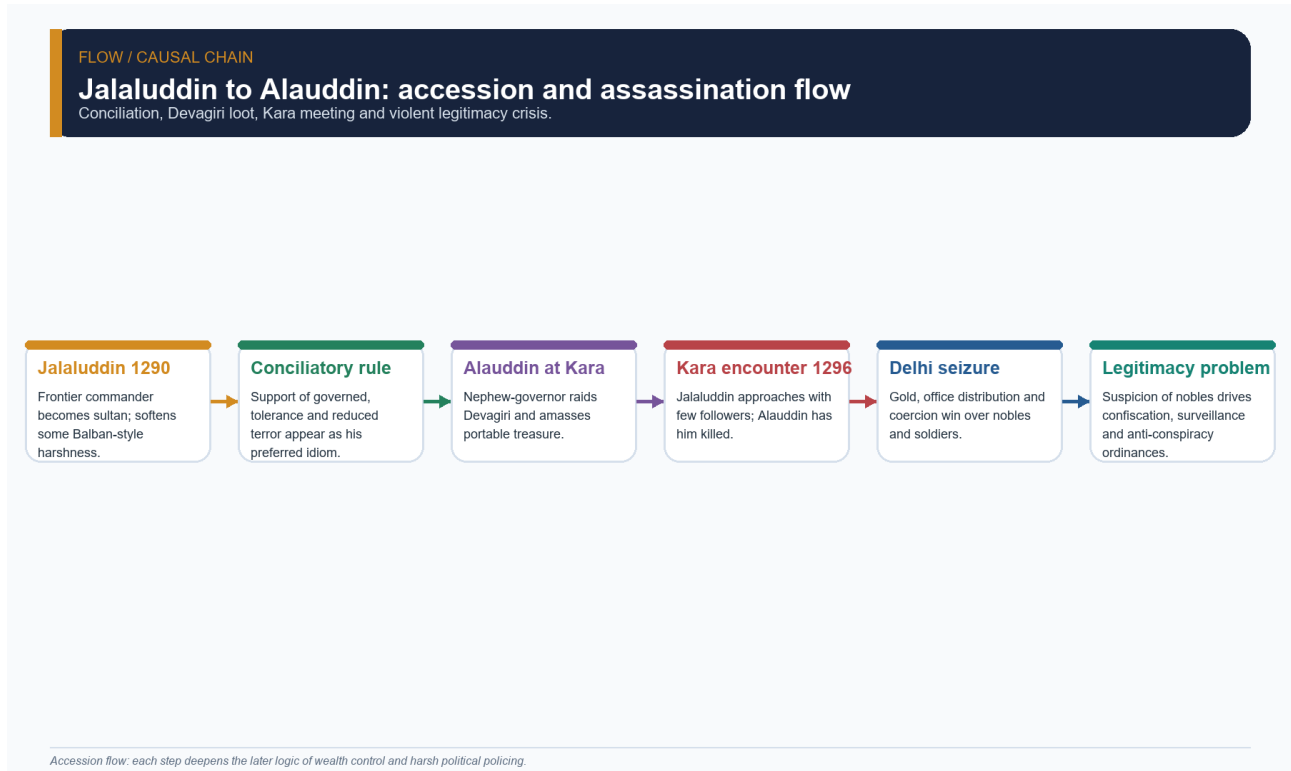
03. Jalaluddin Firuz Khalji and Alauddin's violent road to power

[FACT] Jalaluddin Khalji came to power in **1290** after overthrowing Balban's weak successors.

[FACT] The concise OCR describes him as the first Sultan clearly to argue that the state in India should rest on the **willing support of the governed**, and that a truly Islamic state was impossible in a land with a Hindu majority.

[ANALYSIS] This made Jalaluddin's kingship **conciliatory by Sultanate standards**, but not pacifist. He remained a frontier commander shaped by Mongol pressure and elite insecurity.

[FACT] Alauddin, then positioned at **Kara/Awadh**, raided **Devagiri/Deogir**, accumulated vast portable wealth, lured Jalaluddin into a vulnerable meeting and had him killed in **1296**.



03. Jalaluddin to Alauddin accession flow

Accession flow. Conciliation, Devagiri loot, the Kara murder and coerced legitimacy together explain the later politics of surveillance and confiscation.

Jalaluddin versus Alauddin

Dimension	Jalaluddin Firuz Khalji	Alauddin Khalji
Tone of kingship	Conciliatory, less harsh than Balban	Severe, suspicious and confiscatory
Legitimacy style	Military support plus softening rhetoric	Seizure by assassination plus wealth redistribution and terror
Frontier context	Continuation of Mongol anxiety	Mongol crises become sharper and more system-shaping
Relation with nobles	Sought support through tolerance and leniency	Sought submission through surveillance, confiscation and bans

Source caution

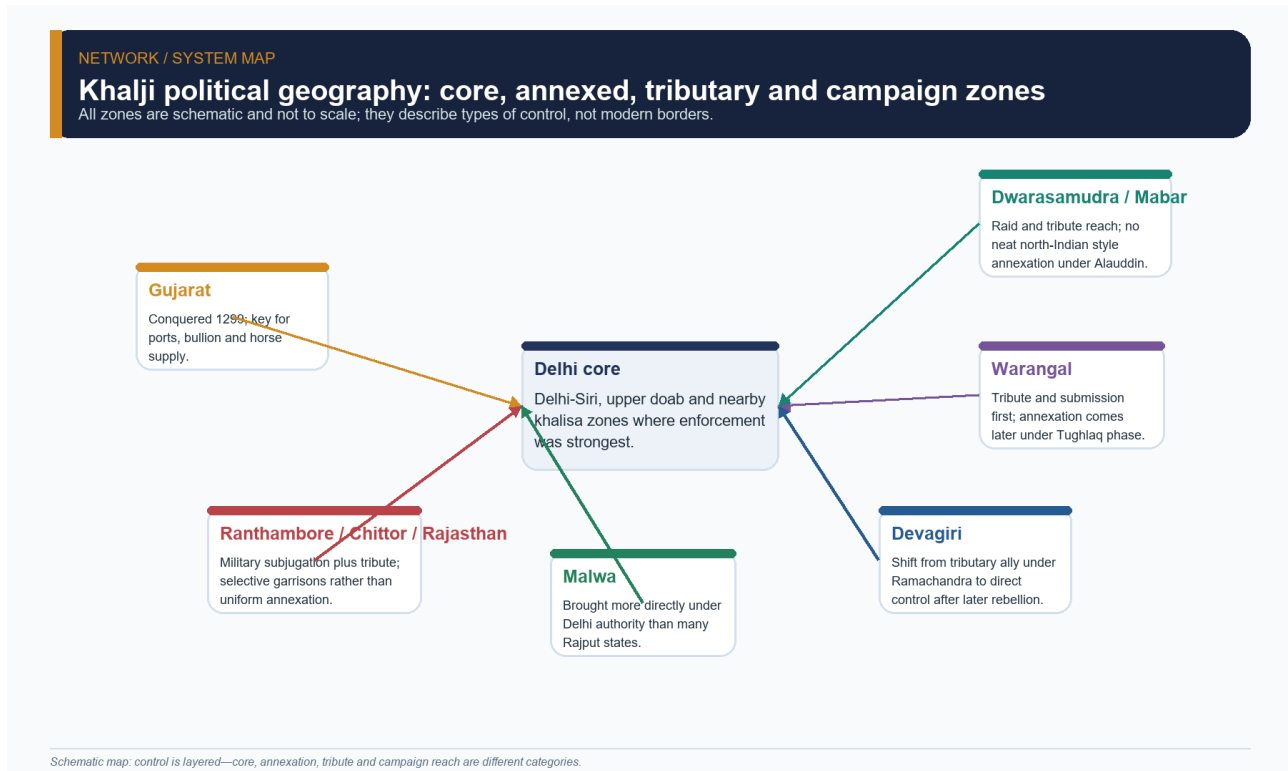
- [LIMIT] Jalaluddin's idealised language survives through later chroniclers, above all Barani, who writes with moral and political agendas.
- [ANALYSIS] Yet even if stylised, the contrast between Jalaluddin's relative leniency and Alauddin's harsher turn is strongly supported by the narrative structure of the local sources.

04. Political geography of Khalji power

[FACT] The Delhi core mattered most. Revenue reform, market regulation, army pay and urban provisioning were strongest in **Delhi-Siri and the upper doab**.

[ANALYSIS] Beyond that core, the Khalji polity worked through **different layers**: annexed provinces, tribute-paying Rajput states, restored subordinate rulers, and deep raiding or campaign zones in the Deccan.

[LIMIT] Do **not** draw a hard modern border around all regions touched by Malik Kafur or later Khalji arms.



04. Political geography: core, annexed, tributary and campaign zones

Schematic political map. It distinguishes Delhi core, stronger annexation, subordinate allies, tribute belts and deep campaign reach. It is not to scale.

Zone language for safe answers

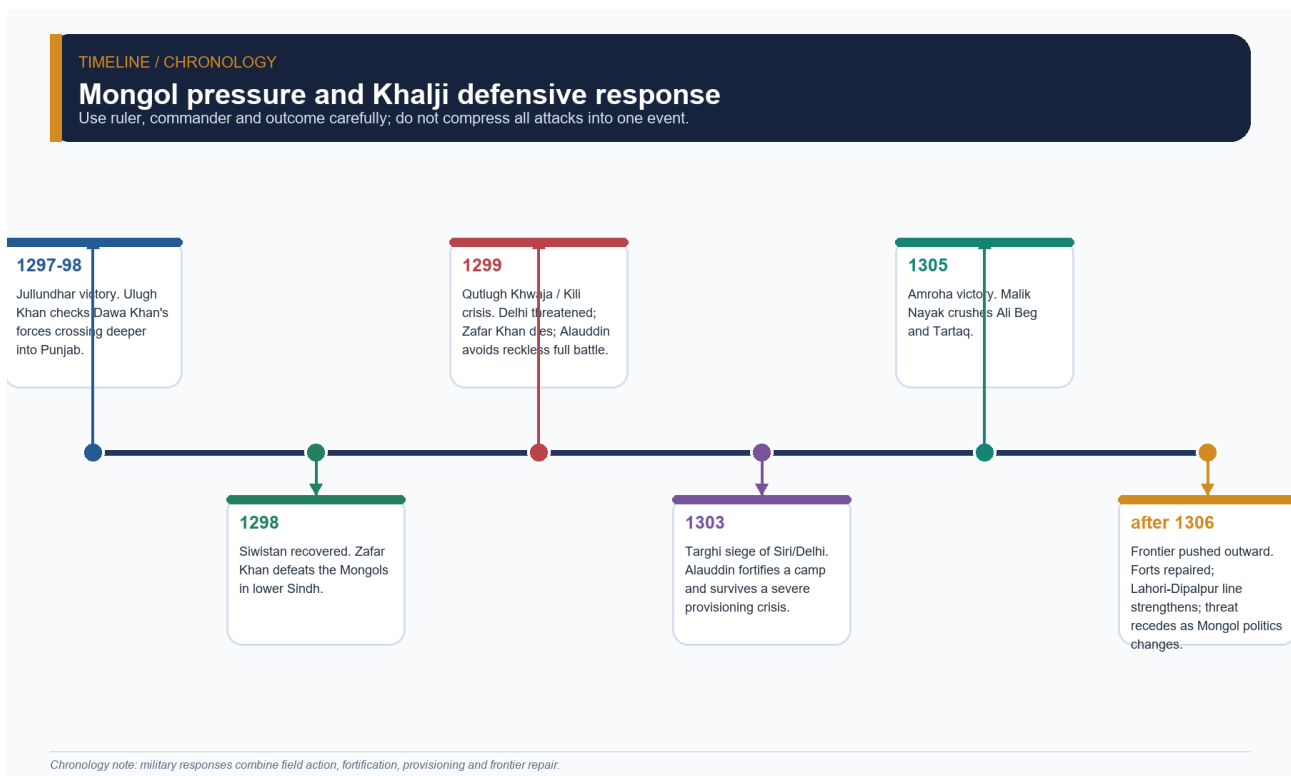
Zone	Safe description
Delhi-Siri and upper doab	core zone of enforcement, provisioning and fiscal extraction
Gujarat and parts of Malwa	more directly incorporated territories
Ranthambore-Chittor-Rajasthan states	subdued or tribute-bearing Rajput polities with selective garrisons
Devagiri under Ramachandra	subordinate ally restored under Delhi suzerainty before later direct turn
Warangal / Dwarasamudra	tributary-success theatre, not neat Alauddin-era annexation
Mabar / Madurai	campaign reach and plunder zone rather than stable Delhi province under Alauddin

05. Mongol threat: accurate chronology and defensive response

[FACT] The local OCR and Topic 03 package together make the following sequence secure: **1297-98 Jullundhar, 1298 Siwistan, 1299 Qutlugh Khwaja / Kili crisis, 1303 Targhi's pressure on Delhi and Siri, 1305 Amroha**, then stronger frontier recovery after Mongol confusion.

[FACT] The 2022 routed Prelims demand directly tests this chronology, especially the distinction between earlier Mongol pressure and the **Alauddin-era siege crisis at Delhi**.

[ANALYSIS] Alauddin's response was not only battlefield courage. It combined **careful refusal of reckless battle**, **fort strengthening**, **camp fortification**, **larger cavalry recruitment** and later **frontier push-back**.



05. Mongol pressure and defensive timeline

Mongol-timeline visual. Year, commander and type of response are kept distinct to avoid PYQ traps.

Chronology table

Year	Mongol leader / episode	Delhi response	Why it matters
1297-98	Dawa Khan's forces cross deeper into Punjab	Ulugh Khan wins at Jullundhar	Shows frontier danger before the major Delhi crisis
1298	Siwistan captured by Mongols in lower Sindh	Zafar Khan recovers it	Confirms recurring frontier warfare
1299	Qutlugh Khwaja / Kili crisis	Alauddin gathers army near Siri; Zafar Khan dies	First truly severe Delhi-facing danger under Alauddin
1303	Targhi pressures Delhi and Siri while Alauddin returns from Chittor	Defensive camp, ditch, provisioning crisis, no reckless open battle	Direct link to Siri, large-army necessity and Delhi supply anxiety
1305	Ali Beg and Tartag defeated near Amroha by Malik Nayak	Crushing defeat for Mongols	Aura of Mongol invincibility breaks in India

UPSC caution

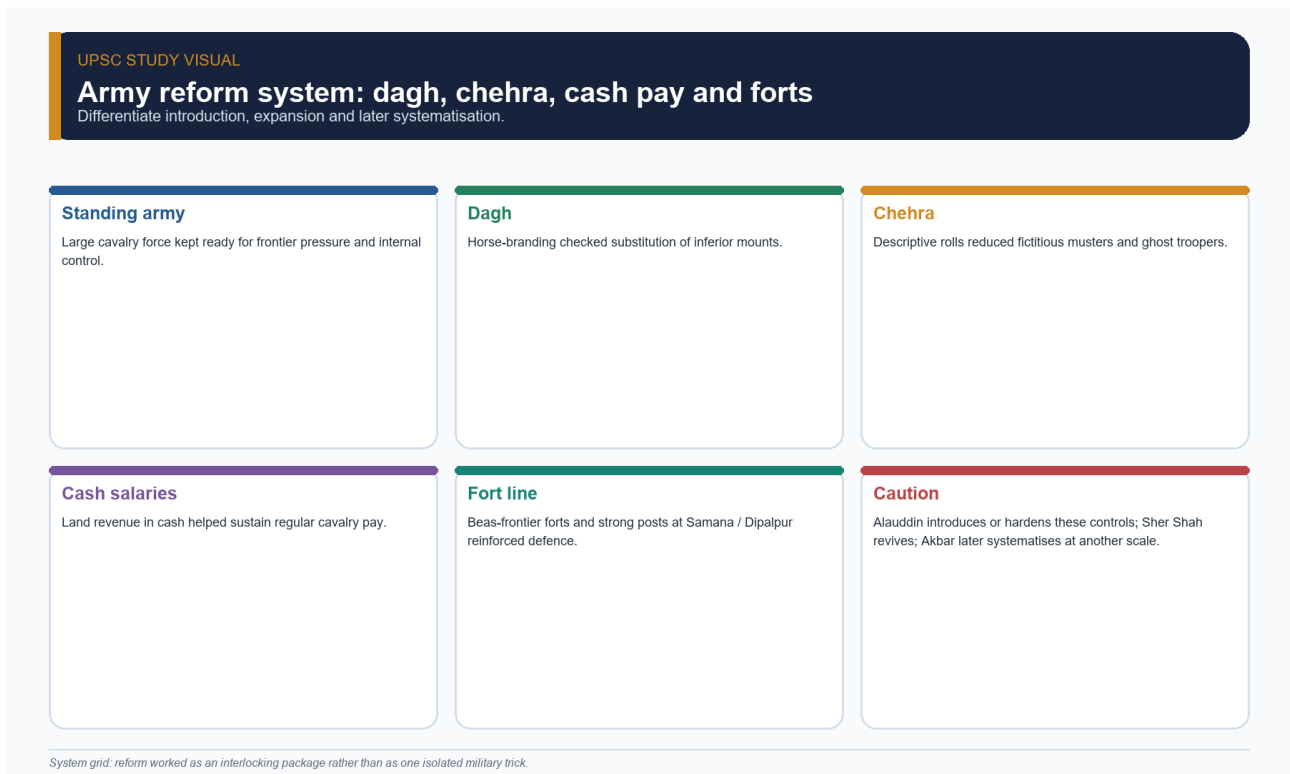
- [LIMIT] "The first Mongol invasion happened under Jalaluddin Khalji" is false. Mongol pressure on the north-west and deeper Indian frontier predates him.
- [LIMIT] It is also unsafe to claim that Mongol danger ended forever in 1305. What changed was the **immediacy and scale** of the threat to Delhi.

06. Army reform: standing cavalry, dagh, chehra, forts and cash

[FACT] Alauddin introduced or hardened a set of military controls that later tradition remembers through **dagh** (horse branding) and **chehra** (descriptive rolls).

[FACT] Topic 07's corrected owner file is explicit: Alauddin introduced these controls in the Sultanate; Sher Shah later revived/adapted them, and Akbar systematised them on a different imperial scale.

[ANALYSIS] The key point is **not** isolated innovation. The key point is the creation of a **checked cavalry system** tied to price control, revenue extraction and frontier security.



06. Army reform system

System visual. Cavalry inspection, cash pay, horse quality and fort repair worked together rather than as separate reforms.

Reform distinction table

Control	Alauddin's role	Why UPSC asks it
Standing cavalry	Expanded and disciplined it under Mongol pressure	Connects external threat to state capacity
Dagh	Brands horses to prevent substitution and fraud	Corrects Mughal-first misconceptions
Chehra	Registers soldiers descriptively to reduce false musters	Shows administrative, not just battlefield, reform
Cash salaries	Revenue in cash helps sustain cavalry pay	Links agrarian and market policy to army affordability
Frontier forts	Repairs and strengthens posts near the Beas and beyond	Prevents reduction of military response to only one battle

Sample pay caution

- [FACT] The concise OCR reports a **cavalryman's annual pay around 238 tankas** in Alauddin's time.
- [LIMIT] OCR and manuscript variation affect the exact rendering of the additional second-horse allowance. Use the figure as a **reported pay scale marker**, not as modern audited payroll certainty.

07. Imperial expansion in the north: Gujarat, Ranthambore, Chittor and Malwa

[FACT] Gujarat was attacked in **1299**. The concise OCR emphasises its fertile wealth, western sea-ports and horse trade significance.

[FACT] Ranthambore fell in **1301** after Hamirdeva's refusal to surrender Mongol fugitives and after a difficult siege.

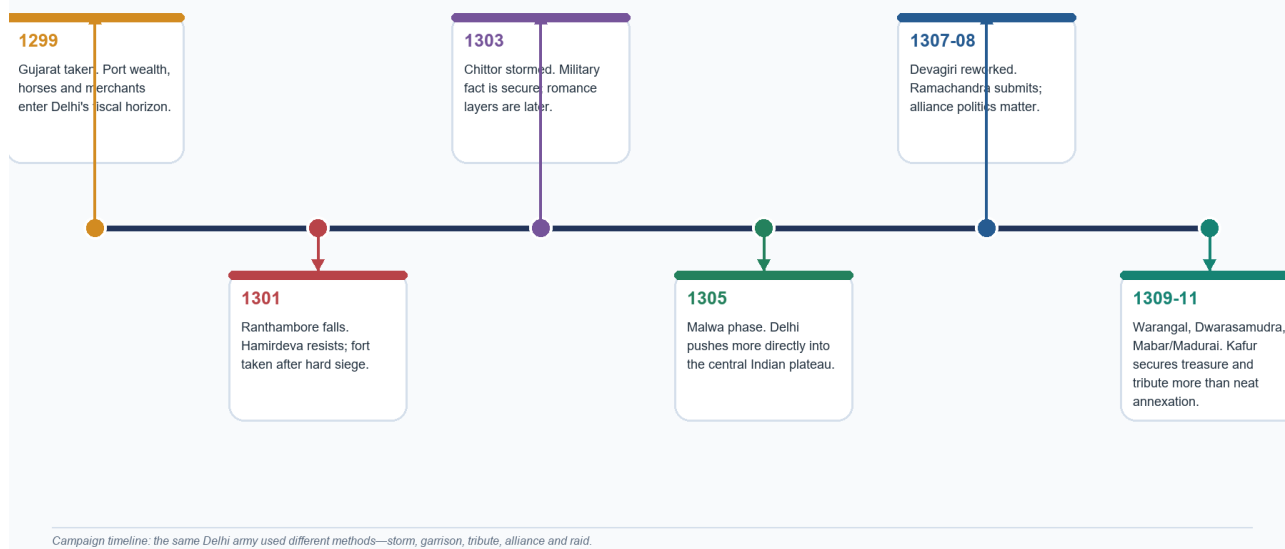
[FACT] Chittor fell in **1303** after a long siege; later romance must be separated from the secure military outcome.

[FACT] Malwa was brought more directly under Delhi control than many Rajput states.

TIMELINE / CHRONOLOGY

Expansion campaign chronology under the Khaljis

Campaigns moved through different theatres with different political outcomes.



07. Expansion campaign chronology

Campaign visual. It keeps different theatres in sequence and warns that conquest method varied by region.

Northern campaigns table

Campaign	Strongest motive mix	Outcome
Gujarat	Port wealth, bullion, merchants, horse supply, strategic western access	Conquered and incorporated
Ranthambore	Strategic fort, Rajput defiance, refuge to Mongol rebels	Hard siege, storm and fall
Chittor	Strategic route, Rajput power, control over central-western passages	Major military victory with long afterlife in memory
Malwa	Plateau power and central Indian consolidation	More direct Delhi administration

Safe phrasing

- [ANALYSIS] Gujarat and Malwa are best described as stronger incorporation zones.
- [ANALYSIS] Rajasthan campaigns are best described as **subjugation plus tribute plus selective garrisoning**, not as one uniform administrative conquest.

08. The Deccan campaigns under Malik Kafur: tribute, treasure and the limits of annexation

[FACT] Malik Kafur rose after Gujarat and became the leading commander of the Deccan campaigns.

[FACT] Ramachandra of Devagiri/Deogir was restored and honoured after submission, showing that **subordinate alliance** could serve Delhi better than immediate annexation.

[FACT] The campaigns to **Warangal**, **Dwarasamudra** and **Mabar/Madurai** yielded treasure, elephants, submission and tribute promises.

[LIMIT] The OCR and repository evidence alike warn against treating these campaigns as a single neat wave of permanent annexation under Alauddin.

COMPARISON / MATRIX

North India versus Deccan: how far did Khalji control really go?

Exam answers must distinguish annexation from subordination, raid and tribute.

Zone / ruler	Mode of Khalji success	Degree of direct control	Exam-safe wording
Gujarat	Conquest and incorporation	Stronger direct control	annexed / administered zone
Ranthambore and Chittor	Siege, storm and tribute politics	Mixed; local dynasties and garrisons matter	subdued Rajput states, not uniform provincial grid
Malwa	Military conquest followed by governorship	More direct than many Rajput areas	brought under Delhi administration
Devagiri under Ramachandra	Submission, restoration, alliance	Initially tributary and cooperative	subordinate ally before later annexing turn
Warangal / Dwarasamudra	Treasure, elephants, tribute promises	No stable Alauddin-era annexation	tributary success, not settled annexation
Mabar / Madurai	Plunder and prestige reach	Least stable control under Alauddin	campaign reach, not durable direct rule

Control matrix: Deccan success is real but layered; do not redraw it as modern state-space.

08. North India versus Deccan control matrix

Control-matrix visual. It separates annexation, restored alliance, tribute extraction and deep campaigning.

Deccan distinction table

Region	Best description under Alauddin
Devagiri under Ramachandra	Restored subordinate ally; later moved toward direct control after rebellion
Warangal	Submission and tribute under Alauddin; later annexation belongs mainly to the Tughlaq phase
Dwarasamudra	Tribute-yielding military success, not stable Alauddin-era province
Mabar / Madurai	Deep raid and plunder zone; control least stable and least directly institutionalised under Alauddin

Why this matters

- [ANALYSIS] Delhi wanted **wealth, prestige and leverage**, not always immediate district-by-district governance.
- [LIMIT] The later Tughlaq annexation story must not be backdated into Alauddin's whole southern policy.

09. Chittor: secure evidence versus later Padmavat tradition

[FACT] The near-contemporary court world, especially Amir Khusrau, securely anchors the **siege of Chittor** and Alauddin's victory.

[FACT] The OCR of Part I states that Khusrau's account does **not** mention the later Padmavati/Padmini legend.

[FACT] The same OCR notes that the Padmini story appears much later and is elaborated by **Malik Muhammad Jaisi** in the sixteenth century.

[ANALYSIS] The historical event and the literary afterlife are both important, but they answer **different questions**.

COMPARISON / MATRIX

Chittor 1303: political-military evidence versus later Padmavat memory

Secure chronology and later literary tradition belong to different evidentiary layers.

Source layer	What it securely gives	What it does not securely prove
Amir Khusrau / near-contemporary court writing	Siege, surrender/assault, massacre claims, Khalji victory	No reliable Padmavati romance narrative
Later chroniclers	Expanded memory of conflict and Rajput honour	Need not preserve eyewitness detail
Malik Muhammad Jaisi's Padmavat (16th c.)	A powerful Sufi-romance afterlife using Chittor as a literary frame	Not a simple documentary source for 1303 court events
Modern source-critical use	Separate siege facts from symbolic memory and gendered honour narratives	Avoid sensational historical certainty from later epic tradition

Source-layer matrix: history and literary memory both matter, but for different questions.

09. Chittor source-layer matrix

Source-layer visual. It separates siege evidence from later romance and memory, which UPSC often tests through elimination traps.

Chittor cautions

- [LIMIT] Do not present the **mirror episode**, the **romantic pursuit of Padmavati**, or the full Jaisi narrative as contemporary fact.
- [LIMIT] Even details such as the exact end of **Ratan Singh** or the form and scale of **jauhar** need careful source-layer separation.
- [FACT] The OCRed Part I notes that Khusrau reports a slaughter narrative at Chittor; this should be treated as conquest rhetoric from a court panegyric, not as a precise demography record.

Exam-safe verdict

Chittor 1303 is a **secure military event**, but **Padmavat** is a later literary construction that transformed the event into a story of desire, honour and memory. The strongest answer keeps those layers separate without dismissing either.

10. Theory of kingship and anti-rebellion controls

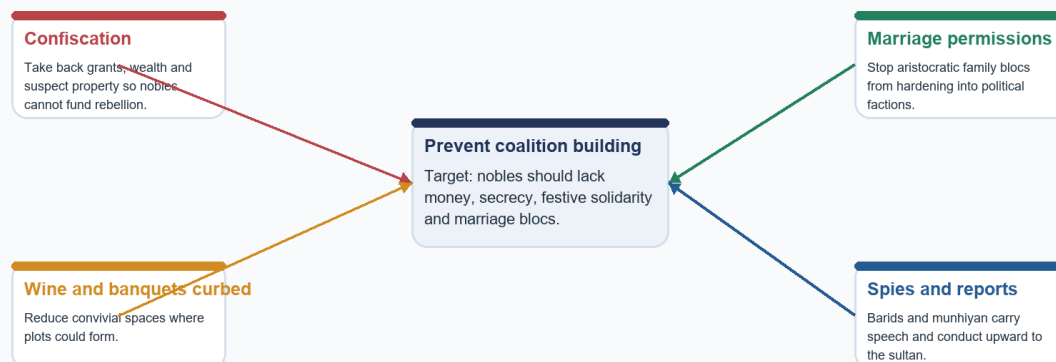
[FACT] After facing rebellions, Alauddin forbade nobles to hold **banquets or festivities**, to form **marriage alliances without permission**, and he restricted **wine and intoxicants**.

[FACT] He also expanded **spying and information networks** and confiscated large accumulations of wealth and grants.

[ANALYSIS] These rules form one coherent political mechanism: **break noble solidarity, reduce resources for conspiracy, increase surveillance, and preserve royal awe**.

Anti-rebellion ordinances: how Alauddin tried to break elite conspiracy

Reported especially by Barani; mechanism is clearer than universal implementation.



Mechanism chart: the aim was political pacification, not moral reform for its own sake.

10. Anti-rebellion ordinance mechanism

Mechanism visual. The reported ordinances target conspiracy-building capacity rather than abstract moral reform.

Ordinance-purpose table

Reported restriction	Anti-rebellion function
Confiscation of wealth, grants or suspicious accumulation	Nobles lose independent funding power
Ban on convivial gatherings and wine	Plotting spaces shrink
Permission for elite marriage alliances	Family blocs cannot easily harden into political factions
Spy networks and reports	Conspiracy becomes riskier and costlier
Punitive severity	Makes royal disobedience visibly dangerous

Limits

- [LIMIT] The detail is heavily Barani-shaped and should be treated as **reported royal policy**.
- [ANALYSIS] Even if enforcement varied, the political logic is strong and fits Alauddin's wider behaviour.

11. Revenue reforms: khalisa core, measurement, half-produce demand and rural effects

[FACT] Satish Chandra's concise and Part I OCRs both describe Alauddin raising land revenue to **around half of the produce** in the **upper doab** and making the area **khalisa**, i.e. directly yielding to the imperial treasury.

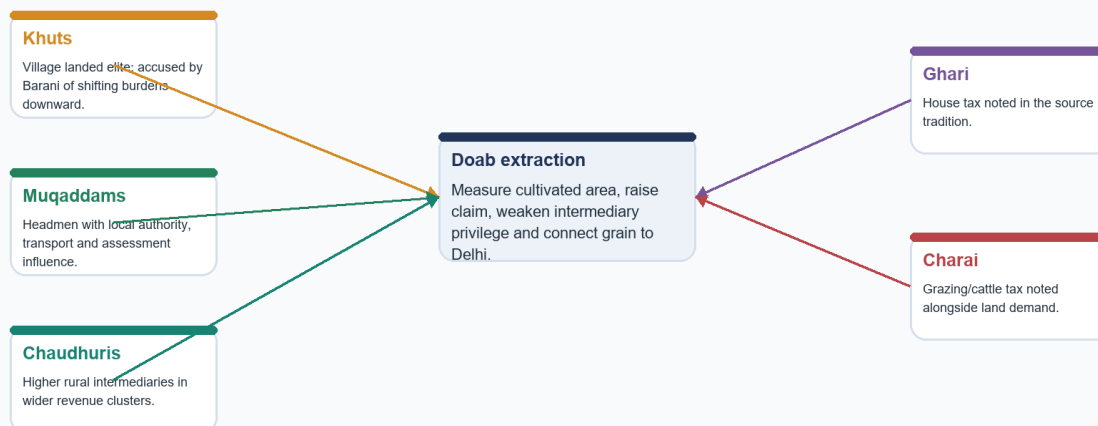
[FACT] The demand was linked to **measurement of cultivated area** and to efforts to prevent the rich from shifting their burden downward.

[FACT] The same sources connect this policy to curbing the privileges of **khuts, muqaddams and chaudhuris**, and to levying **ghari** and **charai** taxes.

[LIMIT] The strongest evidence concerns **core zones**, not the entire empire.

Revenue reform chain and rural hierarchy

Half-produce demand, khalisa concentration and intermediary control were strongest in core zones.



Hierarchy visual: rural power was not abolished; it was attacked, negotiated and partly restored.

11. Revenue reform chain and rural hierarchy

Revenue visual. It links measurement and state demand to the struggle with local intermediaries and to Delhi's grain economy.

Rural hierarchy and policy

Actor or levy	Evidence-led interpretation
Khuts / muqaddams / chaudhuris	Local landed or intermediary elites whose inherited advantages Alauddin tried to cut back
Measurement	Intended to tie demand to cultivated holding rather than negotiated lump sums
Half-produce demand	Heavy extraction aimed at maximising state resources in fertile core areas
Ghari / charai	House and grazing/cattle taxes mentioned in the source tradition
Direct collection	Tightens state-village relationship in khalisa zones

Source caution

- [LIMIT] Barani's dramatic language about rural elites becoming destitute and their women working in Muslim houses is moral-political rhetoric and must not be read literally line by line.
- [ANALYSIS] The deeper point remains valid: Alauddin attacked the fiscal autonomy of rural intermediaries and tried to shift the state's relationship more directly onto cultivators and the local produce stream.

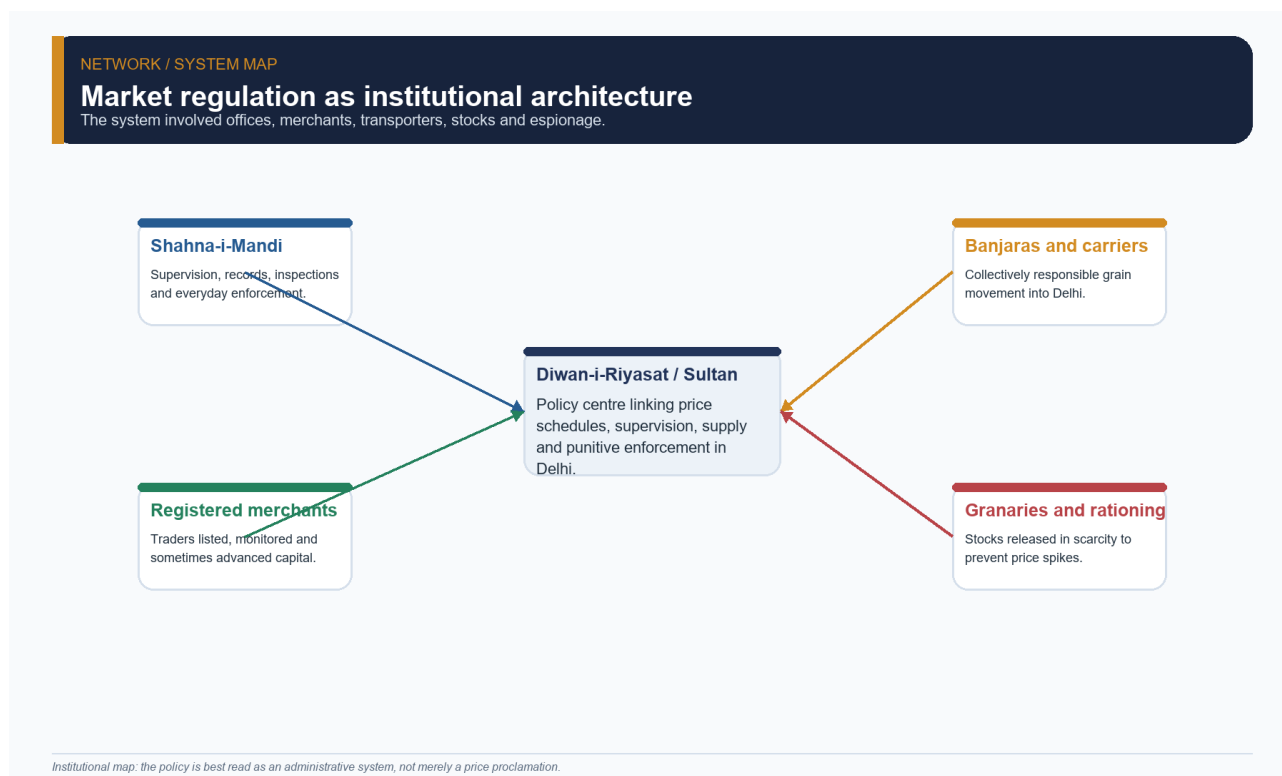
12. Market regulation as an integrated institutional system

[FACT] The concise OCR states that Alauddin set up three main markets at Delhi: one for **foodgrains**, a second for **costly cloth**, and a third for **horses, slaves and cattle**.

[FACT] Each was supervised by a **shahna**, with merchant registers and strict oversight. Topic 04's advanced owner additionally identifies the higher regulatory umbrella as the **Diwan-i-Riyasat**.

[FACT] The system also used **registered merchants, banjaras, state granaries, espionage** and **punitive enforcement**.

[ANALYSIS] The market policy is therefore best read as a **city-scale administrative architecture**, not a mere price edict.



12. Market regulation institutional architecture

Institutional visual. Supervision, grain movement, stockholding and merchant registration all plug into the same Delhi-centred system.

Institutional table

Institutional node	Function
Sultan / Diwan-i-Riyasat	Policy centre and top supervision
Shahna-i-Mandi	Day-to-day regulated market supervision
Merchants and registers	Track supply, location, identity and compliance
Banjaras	Move grain to the capital under monitored conditions
State granaries	Buffer stocks in scarcity and siege
Spies / informants	Detect evasion, overpricing and collusion

13. The four market clusters and the problem of price schedules

[FACT] The sources securely describe **three named physical market clusters**; Topic 04 uses a **fourth analytical cluster** to capture general regulated commodities beyond the three named spaces.

[FACT] The concise OCR preserves sample Barani-linked schedules: wheat at **7 1/2 jitals per man**, barley at **4**, good rice at **5**; a first-grade horse at roughly **100-120 tankas/zankas**, and a tattu/pony at **10-25**.

[LIMIT] These are **reported schedule markers**, not proof of immutable empire-wide prices. Units and manuscript/OCR spellings vary.

COMPARISON / MATRIX

Four controlled market clusters in exam answers

The source speaks clearly of three named markets; the fourth box is an analytical commodity cluster, not a separate ministry.

Market cluster	Main goods	Why controlled	Key caveat
Grain mandi	Wheat, barley, rice and staples	Urban provisioning and soldier subsistence	Best attested and most central
Sarai-i-Adl / cloth	Fine textiles, luxury cloth, imported fabric	Contain elite consumption and wider price ripple effects	Source naming varies in OCR and later summaries
Horse, cattle and slave market	Warhorses, ponies, cattle, slaves	Cavalry quality and service economy	Horse grades and units come mainly through Barani
General controlled goods	Sugar, oil, vegetables, needles and household items	Keep the controlled-price world coherent beyond grain alone	Analytical grouping rather than clearly separate physical market

Comparison matrix: use "market clusters" when a question expects breadth beyond one mandi.

13. Four market comparison matrix

Comparison visual. It distinguishes the grain mandi, cloth/luxury market, horse-cattle-slave market and a broader controlled-commodities cluster.

Market-cluster table

Cluster	Goods	Function	Caveat
Grain mandi	Wheat, barley, rice and staples	Urban provisioning and salary-value preservation	Best attested
Sarai-i-Adl / cloth sphere	Fine textiles and expensive cloth	Contain elite-consumption prices and wider inflationary spillover	OCR and later naming vary
Horse-cattle-slave market	Warhorses, ponies, cattle, slaves	Army quality and service economy	Numbers are heavily Barani-mediated
Wider controlled commodities	Oil, sugar, vegetables, tools and daily-use goods	Make the price regime coherent beyond grain	Analytical category, not necessarily a separate market square

Exam-safe price note

- [ANALYSIS] If a question demands an example, use one or two **sample reported prices**, name **Barani via Satish Chandra**, and immediately add a unit/manuscript caveat.

14. Grain supply, banjaras, granaries and rationing in scarcity

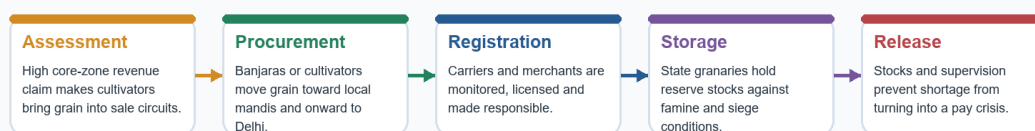
[FACT] Satish Chandra's concise OCR says Alauddin forced cultivators, especially through cash demand and pressure, to sell grain at low rates to **banjaras**, who carried it to towns at state-fixed prices.

[FACT] The same OCR and the advanced owner note that all **banjaras** were registered and collectively responsible, while the state also built **warehouses or granaries**.

[FACT] Grain was released when there was famine or a danger of shortfall.

Grain supply chain: field to Delhi under regulated conditions

This was the practical heart of the military-fiscal system.



Supply-chain visual: regulation worked through logistics, not only through punishments.

14. Grain supply and scarcity flow

Supply-chain visual. It shows why a price system needed logistics, storage and coercive monitoring.

Mechanism steps

1. [FACT] Core-zone extraction increases the state-visible grain stream.
2. [FACT] Cash demand and monitored sale channels push grain into market circulation.
3. [FACT] Banjaras and merchants become registered transport links.
4. [FACT] State granaries cushion shortage and siege conditions.
5. [ANALYSIS] Delhi can thereby keep staple prices from exploding and maintain the real worth of fixed salaries.

Important qualification

- [LIMIT] Part I's OCR itself notes that practice varied, because **some cultivators brought grain directly to local mandis**. The system was forceful, but not perfectly uniform.

15. The military-fiscal causal chain: revenue -> grain -> prices -> salary -> army

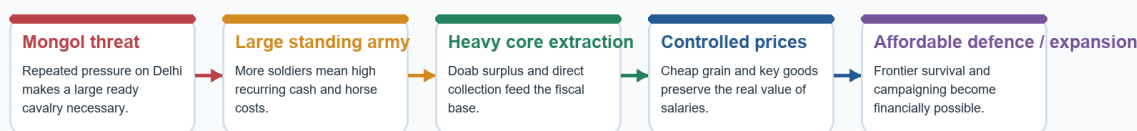
[FACT] The most quoted argument in Topic 04's base files is that Mongol danger forced Alauddin to maintain a large cavalry army, but he lacked unlimited treasure.

[FACT] Hence land revenue, grain movement and fixed prices worked together so that a reported pay scale of around **238 tankas annually** for a cavalryman remained viable.

[ANALYSIS] This is the strongest single answer-spine for the topic because it connects **village extraction, urban provisioning, cavalry affordability** and **frontier defence**.

Military-fiscal causal chain of Alauddin's system

The famous reforms make the most sense when read as one chain.



Causal chain: this is the safest analytical spine for GS-I answers on market reforms.

15. Military-fiscal causal chain

Causal-chain visual. It translates the famous reforms into a linked state-capacity mechanism rather than a list of isolated measures.

Chain table

Link	Historical content
Mongol threat	Repeated major attacks exposed Delhi's vulnerability
Need for large standing army	More cavalry, more horses, more permanent expense
Heavy doab extraction	Generates grain and cash basis for the centre
Controlled prices	Preserves the real value of salaries and mounts
Affordable frontier security	Makes defence and campaign mobility financially possible

Why this is not socialism

- [ANALYSIS] The beneficiaries were first of all the **state and army**.
- [ANALYSIS] Urban consumers benefited, but that was secondary to the military-fiscal logic.
- [LIMIT] A coercive capital-centred regime preserving cheap provisions for soldiers is not the same as a welfare or redistributive ideology.

16. Why did Alauddin regulate markets? Objectives, instruments and limits

[DEBATE] Motives were multiple: military necessity, anti-noble politics, urban provisioning and price discipline all mattered.

[FACT] Topic 04's basic and advanced owners place the **military-fiscal motive** at the centre.

[FACT] The same evidence also shows anti-noble design, because wealth, social gatherings and autonomous elite networking were directly targeted.

[LIMIT] Avoid monocausal certainty. The system can be **primarily** military-fiscal without excluding other motives.

COMPARISON / MATRIX

Price control: objectives, instruments and limitations

Several motives can coexist; do not force one-cause explanations.

Interpretive lens	Objective claimed	Main instruments	Main limit
Military-fiscal	Maintain cavalry on controlled cash salaries	Revenue, markets, grain supply, horse control	Depends on coercive enforcement
Anti-noble politics	Deny aristocrats wealth and autonomous patronage	Confiscation, surveillance, festive restrictions	Elite resistance returns after the ruler dies
Urban provisioning	Avoid panic, hoarding and siege-time famine in Delhi	Granaries, registration, rationing in scarcity	Works best in and around the capital
Moralised narrative	Barani frames profiteers and low-born groups through his own prejudice	Didactic storytelling	Cannot be used as neutral statistical proof

Interpretive matrix: multiple motives overlap, but the military-fiscal lens best integrates the whole system.

16. Objectives, instruments and limits

Interpretive matrix. It prevents simplistic one-cause readings and keeps instrument and limit attached to each motive claim.

Motivation table

Motive	Evidence-led assessment
Military necessity	Strongest integrative explanation; best links army, grain and salaries
Anti-noble strategy	Strong secondary explanation; fits confiscation and social restrictions
Urban provisioning	Clearly present, especially in the grain and granary system
Anti-inflation or administrative rationality	Present in effect, but not best detached from military needs

Limits table

Limit	Why it matters
Delhi focus	Prevents empire-wide overstatement
Coercive administrative cost	Explains why durability was low
Dependence on ruler's will	Explains rapid post-1316 unraveling
Source dependence on Barani	Prevents statistical certainty and ideological slogans

17. Enforcement, espionage, punishments and the black-market problem

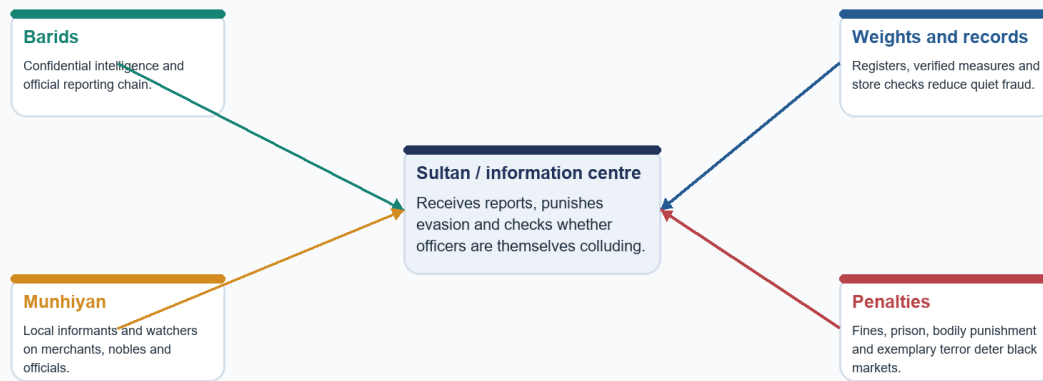
[FACT] The local sources repeatedly stress strict punishment for **overpricing**, **false weights**, **fraudulent horse supply** and other evasions.

[FACT] Barids and munhiyan are part of the Sultanate information world; Topic 04's advanced owner and Topic 07's institutional bank justify their use here.

[ANALYSIS] Such a system could function only if the ruler distrusted both **merchants** and **his own officials**.

Enforcement and espionage network

The policy assumed constant information flow upward and severe penalties downward.



Network visual: fear, paperwork and local reporting worked together.

17. Enforcement and espionage network

Network visual. It shows how fear, record keeping and upward reporting reinforced the regulated market world.

Enforcement points

- [FACT] Registers and verification mattered.
- [FACT] Weights and measures were monitored.
- [FACT] State advances to merchants are reported in the cloth sector, especially with **Multani traders**.
- [ANALYSIS] This shows that Alauddin did not eliminate commerce. He **disciplined** and channelled it.

Black-market caution

- [LIMIT] No coercive price regime abolishes evasion entirely.
- [ANALYSIS] The very intensity of surveillance suggests that slippage, collusion and quality substitution were real risks.

18. Effectiveness, geographic scope, monetisation and urban economy

[FACT] Part I's OCR states that one significant effect of Alauddin's agrarian reforms was the furthering of the **growth of a market economy** in villages and a more integral relationship between town and country.

[FACT] The concise OCR also notes that **Delhi became the biggest market for fine cloth** after large advances were made to traders bringing goods there.

[FACT] Land revenue in cash helped pay soldiers in cash; this fits a wider **monetisation and urban-provisioning** story rather than the destruction of trade.

Effectiveness and geographic scope

Alauddin's system was impressive but not universal, cheap or durable.

Zone / issue	What likely worked	What should be qualified
Delhi city	Staple provisioning, monitored retail and army support were strongest here.	Most vivid evidence is capital-centred.
Upper doab / nearby khalisa	Revenue extraction, measurement efforts and grain linkage mattered most here.	Do not extend identical practice to every province.
Other north Indian towns	Some follow-on effects likely through army and prestige.	Direct proof is thinner than for Delhi.
Deccan / distant provinces	Tribute and campaign finance mattered more than daily price discipline.	No evidence for empire-wide fixed-price uniformity.
After 1316	Some fiscal habits linger; political memory remains.	Detailed market-control package unravels quickly after the ruler's death.

Scope matrix: ask always "where, for whom, and for how long?"

18. Effectiveness and geographic scope matrix

Scope visual. It asks the essential exam questions: where did the system work, for whom did it work, and how durable was it?

Effectiveness verdict

Claim	Verdict
The system was effective in Delhi provisioning and salary stabilisation	[ANALYSIS] broadly yes
The system covered the entire empire with equal depth	[LIMIT] no secure evidence
The system destroyed commerce	[LIMIT] false; it redirected and regulated commerce
The system outlived Alauddin easily	[LIMIT] false; the detailed package frayed rapidly

Cash, trade and town-country linkage

- [FACT] Cash demand linked cultivators more tightly to mandis.
- [FACT] Multani traders and other merchants remained active.
- [ANALYSIS] Alauddin's system therefore intensified **monetised circulation under coercive supervision**, rather than ending the market.

19. Alauddin, ulema, religion and political expediency

[FACT] The advanced OCR preserves the famous Barani-reported argument in which Alauddin prioritises what is necessary for the **state** over neat conformity to **shara**.

[LIMIT] Because Barani writes later, the exact wording must be treated cautiously.

[ANALYSIS] Even with that caution, the political principle is clear: Alauddin did not let juristic scruple alone define statecraft. But that does **not** turn him into a modern secular ruler.

COMPARISON / MATRIX

State, ulema and political reasoning: use with caution

Neither Jalaluddin nor Alauddin fits a modern secularism-versus-theocracy binary.

Issue	Evidence-led reading	Necessary caution
Jalaluddin	Reported willing-support language and recognition of India's Hindu majority.	Normative statement does not erase coercion or dynastic violence.
Alauddin and shara	Barani reports the ruler prioritising state necessity over juristic neatness.	Speech may be stylised by later Barani and tied to a specific crisis.
Non-Muslims / agrarian order	Most taxed cultivators were non-Muslim because most subjects were; policy was fiscal before it was doctrinal.	Avoid communal over-reading of every revenue measure.
Ulema	Honoured and present, but not sovereign over policy.	Do not describe the regime as a modern secular state either.

Caution matrix: political expediency, not modern ideology, is the safest phrase.

19. State-ulema political reasoning caution

Caution visual. It keeps Jalaluddin's support rhetoric, Alauddin's state necessity and the limits of modern ideological labelling distinct.

Exam-safe religion-state statements

Statement	Safe?	Why
Alauddin separated religion from politics in a modern secular sense	No	The idiom is one of reason of state, not constitutional secularism
The Khalji state was a pure ulema-run theocracy	No	Political decisions repeatedly overrode or supplemented juristic preference
Agrarian policy should be read only as anti-Hindu policy	No	The demographic majority of taxpayers was Hindu, but the policy's internal logic is fiscal-military
Jalaluddin and Alauddin were identical in state-religion reasoning	No	Jalaluddin's rhetoric of support differs from Alauddin's harder reason-of-state stance

Jizya and non-Muslims

- [LIMIT] Jizya is not the main analytical axis of Topic 04.
- [ANALYSIS] For this owner, **kharaj, ghari, charai, confiscation and market control** matter far more than a communal template.

20. Architecture and urbanism: Siri, Alai Darwaza, Alai Minar, Hauz-i-Alai

[FACT] The concise culture chapter states that Alauddin built his capital at **Siri**, planned a tower twice the height of the Qutb Minar but left it incomplete (**Alai Minar**), and added the **Alai Darwaza** to the Qutb complex.

[FACT] The same chapter says that the Alai Darwaza's dome and arches were, for the first time in the assigned source, built on **correct scientific lines**.

[FACT] The same source also notes that the **Hauz Khas** area later became a pleasure and madrasa complex under Firuz, while the reservoir itself goes back to Alauddin's **Hauz-i-Alai**.

COMPARISON / MATRIX

Siri, Alai Darwaza, Alai Minar and Hauz-i-Alai / Hauz Khas

Topic 04 owns political meaning; Topic 11 owns full formal architectural analysis.

Monument / urban project	Secure attribution	Why it matters for Topic 04
Siri	Alauddin's new capital / fortified urban response	Mongol-defence, army presence and urban assertion
Alai Darwaza	Alauddin-era gateway at the Qutb complex	Mature scientific arch-and-dome phase and Khalji self-confidence
Alai Minar	Alauddin's unfinished monumental ambition	Shows imperial scale and incomplete overreach
Hauz-i-Alai / later Hauz Khas setting	Reservoir associated with Alauddin; Firuz later adds madrasa-tomb ensemble around it	Urban water, provisioning and later reuse across reigns

Architecture matrix: attribution and later reuse must be separated.

20. Siri and Alai architectural comparison

Architecture visual. Topic 04 uses these monuments to read political ambition, defence and urban provisioning, while Topic 11 owns the fuller stylistic analysis.

Monument table

Monument or urban project	Topic 04 significance
Siri	New defended royal space associated with Mongol pressure and army concentration
Alai Darwaza	Khalji confidence, urban ceremonial framing and mature arch-dome technique
Alai Minar	Imperial ambition visibly left unfinished
Hauz-i-Alai / later Hauz Khas setting	Water, urban provisioning and long-lived reuse across dynasties

Important art-history caution

- [FACT] Topic 11's corrected owner files stress that **Balban's tomb** is the first surviving true arch in the assigned sequence.
- [LIMIT] Therefore do not write that Alai Darwaza was "India's first true arch". It marks **mature** mastery, not the earliest surviving example in this repository's source discipline.

21. Sources, Amir Khusrau and the cultural archive of the Khalji age

[FACT] Topic 07's Persian-source bank and the OCR evidence together support the following source map: **Barani, Amir Khusrau, Isami**, plus inscriptions, coins and monuments.

[FACT] The concise OCR calls Amir Khusrau the leading Persian writer of the age and notes his pride in being Indian; Topic 11 also uses him as a high-yield cultural bridge without indulging the myth that he invented every later musical form.

[ANALYSIS] The Khalji archive is therefore rich but uneven: a courtly Persian world records conquest, regulation and urban ambition better than village experience or subaltern voice.

Source-criticism matrix for the Khalji period

Use chronology, genre and patronage before trusting any vivid detail.

Source	Best use	Main limit
Barani	Alauddin's ordinances, market rules, political ideology, later memory of regime	Later, aristocratic, moralising and not statistically neutral
Amir Khusrau	Campaign sequence, court language, conquest panegyric, Chittor and Deccan atmosphere	Court praise, literary flourish, silences on what weakens the patron
Isami	Alternative narrative threads on Deccan and early Tughlaq transitions	Writing after displacement and with retrospective agendas
Inscriptions / monuments / coins	Names, titles, spaces, building programmes and durable political claims	They do not by themselves map administrative reach or motive

Source matrix: reconstruct the period by triangulation, not by any single chronicle.

21. Source-criticism matrix

Source matrix. It keeps date, genre and patronage at the centre of interpretation.

Source-use table

Source	Best use for Topic 04	Main caveat
Barani	Ordinances, price controls, elite ideology, later memory of Alauddin	Later, moralising, aristocratic, anti-low-born bias
Amir Khusrau	Campaign narrative atmosphere, court culture, contemporary panegyric, Chittor and Deccan framing	Literary flourish, court patronage and selective silence
Isami	Useful alternative lens on Deccan and transition	Retrospective and shaped by displacement
Monuments / coins / inscriptions	Durable claims, urban ambition, titles and built environment	Cannot alone prove the daily depth of enforcement

Why source criticism matters here

- [LIMIT] Barani is not a statistical officer.
- [LIMIT] Khusrau is not a neutral field report.
- [ANALYSIS] The strongest answers triangulate **reported rule**, **material evidence** and **modern caution**.

22. Malik Kafur, succession politics, Mubarak Shah, Khusrau Khan and the Tughlaq transition

[FACT] Malik Kafur rose high under Alauddin, became **malik naib / vice-regent**, and after Alauddin's death helped elevate a minor son while blinding or imprisoning rivals.

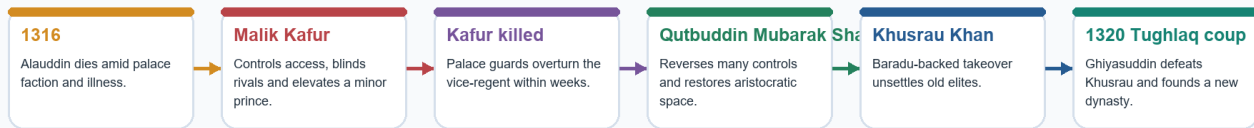
[FACT] He was then quickly killed by palace guards.

[FACT] **Qutbuddin Mubarak Shah** reversed many agrarian and market-control regulations to gain support.

[FACT] **Khusrau Khan** then seized power, and **Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq** defeated him in **1320**.

From Alauddin's death to Tughlaq takeover

The speed of collapse reveals the limits of ruler-dependent coercive institutions.



Succession flow: after 1316, institutions remain but disciplined obedience breaks fast.

22. Succession and fall flow

Succession visual. It shows how quickly the coercive political order destabilised once the ruler disappeared.

Political reading

- [ANALYSIS] The post-1316 sequence demonstrates that institutions without a stable succession ethic can remain **formally present** yet lose their disciplining capacity.
- [LIMIT] It would still be wrong to say that everything vanished overnight. Delhi, iqta logic, army routines and urban infrastructures survived into the Tughlaq order. What collapsed first was **Alauddin's personal grip**.

Bounded owner handoff

- [FACT] Topic 04 stops at the **hard-fought Tughlaq takeover**.
- [FACT] Topic 05 owns Ghiyasuddin's settled policy, Muhammad bin Tughlaq's large-scale annexation and Firuz's later departures.

23. Historiography: coercion, economy and source-caution

[DEBATE] Modern interpretations do not disagree on everything. They broadly agree that Alauddin built an unusually formidable coercive state for his context. They disagree more on how **uniform, intentional, economically transformative** or **durable** that state really was.

[FACT] Satish Chandra's local books give the controlling line for this repository: broadening of the ruling class, Mongol-driven military necessity, strong but not universal market control, and constant caution about Barani's veracity.

COMPARISON / MATRIX

Historiography: how scholars frame Alauddin and the Khaljis

Use as interpretive lenses, not as slogans or quotation-mines.

Scholar / approach	Main emphasis	Safe takeaway for UPSC
Satish Chandra	Broadening of ruling-class social base; Mongol-driven military-fiscal logic; caution about Barani's veracity	Balanced, source-aware, Delhi-centred but not blindly statist
K. S. Lal (older centralisation-heavy reading)	Strong despotism, severe controls and exceptional central power	Useful reminder of coercive reach, but soften claims of uniform total control
Irfan Habib-style agrarian-economic reading	Surplus extraction, monetisation, market linkages and state capacity	Best used to explain revenue-market-army linkage rather than "socialism"
Recent source-critical tendency	Different regions and sources preserve different layers of reality and exaggeration	Always separate policy intent, reported rule and proven implementation

Historiography matrix: the strongest answers combine coercion, economy and source caution.

23. Historiography comparison

Historiography visual. It helps position Satish Chandra's balanced reading among stronger centralisation-heavy and agrarian-economic lenses.

Historiography table

Lens	High-value takeaway
Satish Chandra	Best repository control: military-fiscal integration plus source caution
Older centralisation-heavy readings associated with K. S. Lal	Useful reminder of coercive depth, but easy to overstate as total uniform control
Agrarian-economic readings associated with Irfan Habib's wider medieval-economic tradition	Useful for monetisation, surplus extraction, town-country linkage and market logic
Recent source-critical practice	Best corrective against romantic or statist excess; always ask what Barani or Khusrav could really know

Exam-safe synthesis

The strongest UPSC answer combines three moves:

1. [ANALYSIS] acknowledge **coercive centralisation**,
2. [ANALYSIS] explain the **economic and military mechanism**,
3. [LIMIT] qualify **scope, source and durability**.

24. Historical significance and GS-I answer spine

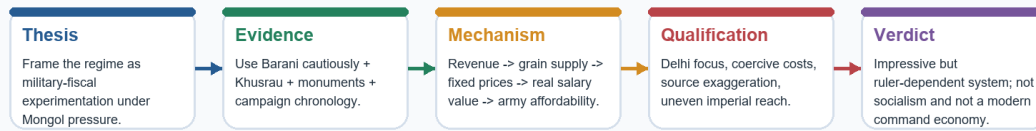
[ANALYSIS] The Khalji period matters because it brought together three processes: **wider elite recruitment**, **coercive military-fiscal experimentation**, and a **Deccan opening** that later dynasties could not ignore.

[ANALYSIS] Delhi became more deeply provisioned and militarised; the doab became more tightly linked to the capital; and imperial ambition reached far beyond earlier Sultanate limits.

[LIMIT] Yet the institutions remained ruler-dependent. Once Alauddin disappeared, the system rapidly exposed its limits.

GS-I answer spine: Alauddin Khalji and market reforms

A ready structure for 10-, 15- and 20-mark answers.



Answer spine: claim -> evidence -> mechanism -> limit -> verdict.

24. GS-I answer spine

Answer-spine visual. It compresses the topic into the sequence thesis -> evidence -> mechanism -> qualification -> verdict.

One-line verdicts for use

- [ANALYSIS] "The Khalji moment was the Delhi Sultanate's sharpest experiment in coercive military-fiscal integration before the Tughlaqs."
- [ANALYSIS] "Alauddin's market reforms were a Delhi-centred instrument for keeping a large cavalry affordable under Mongol pressure."
- [ANALYSIS] "The Khalji revolution broadened access to the ruling class without democratising the polity."
- [ANALYSIS] "The period opened the Deccan politically while proving the limits of ruler-dependent control."

PART II - Learning MCQ loops**Learning MCQ 01**

Question: The safest meaning of the phrase "Khalji revolution" is:

- A. a widening of the ruling elite beyond the old Turkish monopoly B. abolition of all hierarchy in the countryside C. conversion of the whole Sultanate into a democratic monarchy D. end of iqta and military slavery in one stroke

Answer: A

Why: It marks a reconfiguration of high-office access, not a mass social revolution.

Learning MCQ 02

Question: Jalaluddin Firuz Khalji is most accurately associated with:

- A. rigid exclusion of all non-Turks from office B. a comparatively conciliatory kingship and support-based rhetoric C. direct annexation of Warangal and Madurai D. the Alai Darwaza and Hauz Khas madrasa

Answer: B

Why: The local sources contrast Jalaluddin's softer tone with Alauddin's harder coercive turn.

Learning MCQ 03

Question: Which statement best captures Alauddin's legitimacy problem after 1296?

A. He inherited an uncontested throne through settled primogeniture. B. He was legitimised mainly by caliphal appointment. C. He seized power through the murder of Jalaluddin and then had to overawe nobles by gold and coercion. D. He was elected by village assemblies of the doab.

Answer: C

Why: The Kara murder, Devagiri loot and later surveillance regime belong to the same legitimacy crisis.

Learning MCQ 04

Question: Under Alauddin, Siri is best described as:

A. the cloth market under Sarai-i-Adl B. a Rajput tributary state in Rajasthan C. the name of Jalaluddin's conciliatory policy D. a new defended capital linked to Mongol pressure and army concentration

Answer: D

Why: Siri anchors the Delhi-facing defence and army-provisioning story.

Learning MCQ 05

Question: Which one of the following is the most secure statement about Mongol chronology under the Khaljis?

A. The 1303 crisis is linked with Targhi and the defended Siri-Delhi position. B. The first Mongol invasion of India began under Jalaluddin Khalji. C. Amroha was a defeat of Alauddin's forces. D. Qutlugh Khwaja invaded after Alauddin's death.

Answer: A

Why: 1303 and Siri belong together; the other options distort chronology.

Learning MCQ 06

Question: In the military reforms of Alauddin Khalji, **dagh** refers to:

A. a descriptive roll of soldiers B. horse-branding for inspection C. a tax on houses D. the Shahna-i-Mandi's cloth register

Answer: B

Why: Dagh checked the substitution of inferior horses.

Learning MCQ 07

Question: Which statement about the Deccan campaigns is the most balanced?

A. All Deccan kingdoms were smoothly converted into full provinces by Alauddin himself. B. The campaigns had no fiscal value and were merely symbolic. C. They mixed tribute, treasure, subordination and, in some cases, a later move toward direct control. D. They were led entirely without the help of subordinate local rulers.

Answer: C

Why: Devagiri, Warangal and Mabar did not all stand in the same political relation to Delhi.

Learning MCQ 08

Question: The most exam-safe reading of the 1303 Chittor episode is that:

A. the full Padmavat mirror episode is contemporary fact B. Alauddin attacked only for romantic motives C. no later literary memory matters at all D. the siege and conquest are secure, but later Padmavat tradition must be separated from near-contemporary evidence

Answer: D

Why: UPSC rewards source layering, not sensational retelling.

Learning MCQ 09

Question: Which rural groups are most centrally associated with Alauddin's anti-intermediary revenue policy?

A. khuts, muqaddams and chaudhurs B. Sufis, qazis and muftis C. Portuguese merchants and Multani traders D. barids and munhiyan

Answer: A

Why: These were the rural intermediaries whose privileges were targeted in core zones.

Learning MCQ 10

Question: The Shahna-i-Mandi is most closely associated with:

A. frontier fortification at Dipalpur B. the supervision of regulated markets C. the office of Mir Bakhshi in the Mughal empire D. the hereditary rights of khuts

Answer: B

Why: The Shahna-i-Mandi belongs to market supervision, not frontier command.

Learning MCQ 11

Question: A major purpose of the grain-granary-banjara system was to:

A. abolish all private trade forever B. convert every province into khalisa territory C. preserve cheap and regular staple supply for Delhi D. replace cavalry with infantry

Answer: C

Why: Provisioning the capital was central to the military-fiscal design.

Learning MCQ 12

Question: Which statement most accurately captures the motivation behind Alauddin's price controls?

A. They were a medieval welfare state experiment for consumer equality. B. They were unrelated to military needs. C. They sought above all to honour juristic orthodoxy. D. They were primarily a military-fiscal device, though urban provisioning and anti-noble effects also mattered.

Answer: D

Why: This is the repository's most evidence-led overall reading.

Learning MCQ 13

Question: The safest statement about Alauddin and shara is:

A. Barani reports a strong reason-of-state stance, but the exact wording cannot be treated as verbatim certainty. B. Alauddin abolished Islam from the Sultanate. C. Alauddin always obeyed the ulema in state affairs. D. The issue is irrelevant to understanding Khalji politics.

Answer: A

Why: It preserves both the political principle and the source caution.

Learning MCQ 14

Question: Alai Darwaza should be remembered in this topic mainly as:

A. the first surviving true arch in the assigned source sequence B. a mature Khalji arch-and-dome monument tied to imperial urban ambition C. an unfinished Rajput watchtower D. evidence that the Khaljis abandoned urban architecture

Answer: B

Why: Topic 11 distinguishes it from Balban's earlier surviving arch while highlighting its mature construction.

Learning MCQ 15

Question: Which source is most indispensable yet most in need of caution for Alauddin's market regulations?

A. Ferishta B. Ibn Battuta C. Ziauddin Barani D. Abul Fazl

Answer: C

Why: Barani is central for the ordinances and market system, but he is late, didactic and aristocratic.

Learning MCQ 16

Question: The quickest single reason why the detailed Alauddin system did not long outlive him is that it:

A. had no relation to the army B. was based only on temple wealth C. faced no succession problems at all D. depended heavily on the personal coercive grip of the ruler and weakened during succession turmoil

Answer: D

Why: The 1316-1320 sequence shows how fast tightly personalised coercive systems can fray.

PART III - Solved practice workbook

Solved topic-specific MCQs

Verified and routed PYQs

PYQ 01 - UPSC Prelims 2022 GS-I (direct routed question; exact wording verified locally; official key unavailable locally)

Question: With reference to Indian history, consider the following statements:

1. The first Mongol invasion of India happened during the reign of Jalal-ud-din Khalji.
2. During the reign of Ala-ud-din Khalji, one Mongol assault marched up to Delhi and besieged the city.
3. Muhammad-bin-Tughlaq temporarily lost portions of north-west of his kingdom to Mongols.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(a) 1 and 2 (b) 2 only (c) 1 and 3 (d) 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: (b) 2 only. Confidence: high.

Model explanation: Statement 1 is incorrect because Mongol pressure and penetration into the north-west predated Jalaluddin Khalji; Topic 03 already anchored pressure in Iltutmish's age and the later Lahore sack. Statement 2 is correct because the **1303 Targhi crisis** brought Mongol pressure up to Delhi and Alauddin's defended Siri position. Statement 3 is unsafe in the wording used and is treated as incorrect in this repository's validated Topic 03 explanation; Muhammad bin Tughlaq had frontier problems and diplomacy, but the statement as framed is not the standard established event.

Why this earns marks: It fixes the chronology by ruler, separates frontier pressure from the Delhi siege crisis and refuses to validate a statement only because it mentions a familiar Tughlaq name.

PYQ 02 - UPSC GS-I 2020 (verified adjacent source question; primary routing elsewhere, but directly valuable for Topic 04 source criticism)

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

Persian literary sources are indispensable for medieval India because they preserve the political language, moral anxieties and courtly horizons of the age. Yet they reflect the spirit of the age only if used with **genre and patronage caution**.

The strongest evidence lies in the Sultanate archive. **Ziauddin Barani's** *Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi* records rulers, nobles, market regulations and ideas of order from Balban to the Tughlaqs. For Topic 04, it is the key source for Alauddin Khalji's ordinances and price-control system. But Barani was a fourteenth-century aristocratic moralist; his hostility to the "low and ignoble" means that vivid numbers, motives and speeches need qualification.

Amir Khusrau's courtly works, including *Khaza'in-ul-Futuh*, illuminate conquest, ceremonial culture and Indo-Persian self-fashioning. His value for the Khalji age is enormous: Chittor, Gujarat and Deccan campaigns all pass through his courtly lens. Yet the same lens is panegyric. He celebrates power better than he documents administrative limits or non-elite suffering.

At the same time, Persian sources widen beyond bare political narrative. They capture elite ideals, religious debate, urban sensibility and the moral language of sovereignty. Their silences are equally revealing: peasants, women outside elite circles and regional society appear unevenly.

Hence, Persian sources do reflect the spirit of the age - but the spirit they show is mediated, courtly and argumentative rather than neutral reportage. They are most powerful when read against inscriptions, monuments, coins and other narrative traditions.

Why this earns marks: The answer opens with a clear thesis, uses named sources from the Khalji age, links each source to what it proves, and qualifies each source instead of treating Persian writing as transparent fact.

PYQ 03 - UPSC GS-I 2023 (verified adjacent Sultanate question; primary routing to broader administration/technology owners)

Question: What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

Model answer:

The Sultanate period did not invent technology from nothing, but it accelerated the diffusion and combination of several techniques in textiles, construction, cavalry management and irrigation. Their effects were strongest in **state capacity, urban life and long-distance exchange**.

In construction, the widespread use of the **true arch, dome and stronger lime mortar** transformed scale and skyline. Topic 04's Khalji phase is crucial here: **Alai Darwaza** marks mature scientific arch-and-dome construction, while **Siri** shows how military pressure could produce new defended urban forms. The impact was not merely aesthetic. Larger covered spaces, gateways and fortified capitals supported royal ceremonial and political control.

In military organisation, improved cavalry inspection through **dagh** and **chehra** under Alauddin Khalji shows technology as administration. Branding horses and maintaining descriptive rolls reduced fraud and preserved army efficiency under Mongol pressure.

In textiles and circulation, the broader Sultanate period saw wider use of the **spinning wheel**, the **cotton-carder's bow**, improved looms and market-linked craft production. This supported urban growth, merchant activity and the provisioning systems on which capitals depended.

The social effect, however, was uneven. These changes strengthened towns, armies, merchants and courts more than they emancipated cultivators. Monumental construction and military inspection served states before they served social equality.

Therefore, Sultanate technological change mattered profoundly, but its historical meaning lies in the interaction of technique with political power, urbanisation and unequal social structure.

Why this earns marks: It answers both parts of the question, uses precise Khalji-era examples, and converts technology into social and political consequences rather than listing devices mechanically.

Original broad-coverage MCQs

MCQ 01

Question: Which statement best expresses the repository's framing of the Khalji period?

A. It is best read through source criticism and state-capacity analysis. B. It should be described chiefly as a medieval socialist experiment. C. It is mainly a romance about Padmavati. D. It has no meaningful continuity with the Mamluk period.

Answer: A

Explanation: Topic 04 deliberately rejects ideological caricature and reads policy through sources, mechanism and scope.

MCQ 02

Question: The "Khalji revolution" most safely refers to:

A. the abolition of iqta assignments B. the widening of the ruling class beyond the old Turkish monopoly C. the replacement of all nobles by village headmen D. the immediate annexation of the whole Deccan

Answer: B

Explanation: Elite composition changed significantly, but society as a whole was not revolutionised.

MCQ 03

Question: Jalaluddin Khalji's political style is best described as:

A. identical to Alauddin's confiscatory style B. pure military despotism without any conciliatory element C. comparatively tolerant and support-oriented by Sultanate standards D. based on abolishing the army's frontier role

Answer: C

Explanation: His rule is remembered for attempting to soften some harsher features of earlier monarchy.

MCQ 04

Question: Alauddin's road to power in 1296 pivoted on:

A. a caliphal nomination received in Delhi B. a village assembly election at Kara C. his architectural patronage at Siri D. the Devagiri loot, the Kara meeting and the murder of Jalaluddin

Answer: D

Explanation: Wealth from Devagiri and the Kara assassination underpin Alauddin's legitimacy problem.

MCQ 05

Question: In Topic 04's political-geography language, the Delhi-Siri-upper doab belt is:

A. the core enforcement and provisioning zone B. only a symbolic ceremonial landscape C. a distant tribute zone D. a purely literary construction of Barani

Answer: A

Explanation: This is where fiscal extraction, grain supply and price control were most deeply tied together.

MCQ 06

Question: The 1303 Mongol episode is most closely linked with:

A. the fall of Warangal B. the fortification of the defended Siri position near Delhi C. the capture of Siwistan D. the treaty with Ramachandra of Devagiri

Answer: B

Explanation: The Targhi crisis is the classic Siri moment in Khalji history.

MCQ 07

Question: Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Qutlugh Khwaja - Mabar campaign B. Targhi - conquest of Gujarat C. Ali Beg and Tartaq - Amroha defeat D. Malik Nayak - siege of Chittor

Answer: C

Explanation: Ali Beg and Tartaq are linked to the Amroha defeat of the Mongols.

MCQ 08

Question: In Alauddin's military administration, **chehra** refers to:

A. a branded horse-mark B. a tax on grazing C. a provincial iqta record D. a descriptive roll of soldiers

Answer: D

Explanation: Chehra helped prevent fictitious musters and false salary claims.

MCQ 09

Question: Gujarat mattered to Alauddin above all because of its:

A. ports, bullion and horse supply connections B. monastic universities only C. frontier snow passes D. role as the Alai Minar's stone quarry

Answer: A

Explanation: Gujarat's ports and wealth strengthened Delhi's fiscal and military position.

MCQ 10

Question: Ranthambore became a major Alauddin target partly because:

A. it housed the Diwan-i-Riyasat B. Hamirdeva protected Mongol fugitives and defied Delhi C. it was the main cloth market of the empire D. Jalaluddin had already annexed it completely

Answer: B

Explanation: Refuge to Mongol rebels and fort strength helped make Ranthambore urgent.

MCQ 11

Question: The safest statement about Chittor 1303 is that:

A. the Padmavat narrative is a near-contemporary documentary account B. no siege took place and the story is wholly fictitious C. a secure siege-and-conquest event later acquired a powerful literary afterlife D. Khusrau wrote only about Padmavati and not about conquest

Answer: C

Explanation: Historical siege and later literary romance occupy different evidentiary layers.

MCQ 12

Question: Malwa under the Khaljis is best described as:

A. a zone never touched by Delhi power B. only a tribute-paying Rajput state without direct intervention C. a purely symbolic claim in court poetry D. more directly brought under Delhi administration than many Rajput states

Answer: D

Explanation: Malwa is one of the clearer cases of stronger political incorporation.

MCQ 13

Question: Ramachandra of Devagiri is important because he:

A. was restored as a subordinate ally and became useful for later Deccan policy B. permanently expelled Delhi from the south C. built the Alai Darwaza D. wrote the Tarikh-i Firuz Shahi

Answer: A

Explanation: His restored, cooperative position shows that not all Deccan policy was immediate annexation.

MCQ 14

Question: Warangal under Alauddin is best characterised as:

A. an unquestioned Delhi province from the start B. a theatre of submission and tribute before later annexation under the Tughlaqs C. outside all Khalji military concern D. identical in status to the upper doab khalisa zone

Answer: B

Explanation: Tribute and submission came first; later annexation belongs mainly to the Tughlaq phase.

MCQ 15

Question: The main political purpose of the ban on elite banquets and marriage alliances was to:

A. encourage Sufi egalitarianism B. increase temple revenues C. break aristocratic coalition-building D. replace horses with elephants

Answer: C

Explanation: These ordinances targeted the social infrastructure of conspiracy.

MCQ 16

Question: Which statement about Alauddin's reported confiscations is most accurate?

A. They were irrelevant to noble politics. B. They abolished all land grants in every province forever. C. They were merely a poetic metaphor. D. They sought to deny nobles the wealth needed for autonomous rebellion.

Answer: D

Explanation: Confiscation and surveillance belong to the same anti-rebellion strategy.

MCQ 17

Question: In the revenue system of Topic 04, **khalisa** most directly means:

A. land whose revenue flowed directly to the imperial treasury B. temple-free land only C. a village committee D. a cash salary scale

Answer: A

Explanation: Khalisa is central to understanding why the doab mattered so much to Delhi.

MCQ 18

Question: Which rural groups are specifically targeted in the source tradition as privileged intermediaries?

A. qazis and muftis B. khuts, muqaddams and chaudhurs C. Chishti saints D. Multani traders

Answer: B

Explanation: They are the classic rural-intermediary trio in Alauddin's revenue debate.

MCQ 19

Question: The best reason to avoid calling Alauddin's price policy "socialism" is that it:

A. eliminated all market exchange B. guaranteed equal welfare to all cultivators C. was aimed chiefly at funding and disciplining a large cavalry under frontier pressure D. arose from nineteenth-century social theory

Answer: C

Explanation: The regime's primary logic was military-fiscal, not redistributive ideology.

MCQ 20

Question: Which institutional cluster most clearly belongs to market regulation?

A. Chihalgani, paibos, sijda and caliphal investiture B. Mansabdars, zat and sawar C. zabt, patta and qabauliyat D. Shahna-i-Mandi, merchant registers, banjaras and state granaries

Answer: D

Explanation: These are the linked regulatory nodes of the Delhi market system.

MCQ 21

Question: Sample prices such as wheat at 7 1/2 jitals per man are best used as:

A. reported schedule markers from Barani via Satish Chandra, with unit caution B. proof of uniform prices across every province and year C. official audited statistics from a modern revenue department D. evidence that merchants disappeared from Delhi

Answer: A

Explanation: They are useful only when accompanied by source and scope caution.

MCQ 22

Question: The grain-granary-banjara system mattered because it:

A. replaced all local mandis B. connected field extraction to capital provisioning under supervision C. ended the use of cash in the countryside D. removed the need for cavalry pay

Answer: B

Explanation: Without this chain, price controls could not stabilise Delhi in practice.

MCQ 23

Question: Which statement best captures the relation between market control and commerce?

A. Alauddin abolished merchants and trade itself. B. Merchants ceased to exist in Gujarat and Delhi. C. The system regulated and channelled commerce rather than eliminating it. D. Trade became irrelevant once grain was stored.

Answer: C

Explanation: State advances, registers and cloth inflow show controlled commerce, not no commerce.

MCQ 24

Question: One lasting economic significance attributed to Alauddin's agrarian reforms in Part I is:

A. the end of all village markets B. complete equality in rural society C. the destruction of the town-country relationship D. the furthering of a market economy and tighter town-country linkage

Answer: D

Explanation: Satish Chandra explicitly notes this broader structural effect.

MCQ 25

Question: Alauddin's reported stance on shara is best read as:

A. a reason-of-state position that qualified juristic neatness without making him a modern secular ruler B. proof that the ulema fully ruled the state C. evidence that religion was irrelevant to the Sultanate D. a direct constitutional theory of secular citizenship

Answer: A

Explanation: The issue is political expediency within a medieval idiom, not modern secularism.

MCQ 26

Question: Which monument is most directly tied to Alauddin's unfinished imperial ambition?

A. Sultan Ghari B. Alai Minar C. Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque D. Tughlaqabad

Answer: B

Explanation: Alai Minar expresses scale and incompleteness in the Khalji phase.

MCQ 27

Question: The safest statement about Hauz-i-Alai / Hauz Khas is:

A. it was wholly unrelated to Alauddin B. it was built by Akbar as a market reservoir C. the reservoir is linked to Alauddin, while Firuz later built around the site D. it was a Mongol frontier fort

Answer: C

Explanation: Topic 04 must separate original reservoir association from later architectural reuse.

MCQ 28

Question: Which source is contemporary but also overtly court-panegyric for Khalji campaigns?

A. Abul Fazl B. Ibn Battuta C. Barani's Fatawa-i Jahandari D. Amir Khusrau's campaign writing

Answer: D

Explanation: Khusrau is invaluable for atmosphere and sequence, but he writes from within court praise.

MCQ 29

Question: Malik Kafur's post-1316 importance lies chiefly in the fact that he:

A. became vice-regent and intervened decisively in succession politics B. restored Jalaluddin to the throne C. founded the Tughlaq dynasty D. led the first Mongol invasion of India

Answer: A

Explanation: His power after Alauddin's death exposes how unstable the succession structure was.

MCQ 30

Question: Qutbuddin Mubarak Shah is especially remembered in Topic 04 because he:

A. restored many of the earlier controls and tightened market regulation still further B. abolished many of Alauddin's agrarian and market controls to gain support C. permanently reunited all Deccan kingdoms with Delhi D. wrote Padmavat

Answer: B

Explanation: His reversals show how ruler-dependent the Khalji regime had been.

MCQ 31

Question: Historiographically, the most useful role of K. S. Lal-type readings in Topic 04 is to:

A. prove that Barani is unnecessary B. deny all military logic to the reforms C. remind us of the regime's coercive depth, while still qualifying total-control claims D. establish Padmavat as contemporary archive

Answer: C

Explanation: Centralisation-heavy readings help foreground coercion, but require scope caution.

MCQ 32

Question: The best concluding line for Topic 04 is that the Khalji phase:

A. ended all later institutional continuity in the Sultanate B. was simply a literary myth C. mattered only for architecture and nothing else D. combined major military-fiscal experimentation with impressive but ruler-dependent coercive institutions

Answer: D

Explanation: This captures both achievement and fragility.

Remedial MCQs - trap correction set

Remedial MCQ 01

Question: Which statement is the best antidote to the label "first socialist"?

A. Alauddin's controls were primarily military-fiscal, not welfare-ideological. B. Alauddin abolished all private property. C. Alauddin's state redistributed land equally among peasants. D. Barani called the system socialist.

Answer: A

Explanation: The policy aimed first at army affordability and Delhi provisioning.

Remedial MCQ 02

Question: The best correction to a romantic Padmavati-only reading of Chittor is:

A. the siege never happened B. the 1303 military event is secure, but the later Padmavat layer is literary memory C. Jaisi was Alauddin's court historian D. Khusrau wrote only about mirrors and romance

Answer: B

Explanation: This is the core source-critical distinction.

Remedial MCQ 03

Question: Which claim most clearly overstates the scope of Alauddin's price controls?

A. They were strongest in Delhi and linked core revenue zones to the capital. B. They relied on merchants, carriers and granaries. C. They operated with equal day-to-day depth across the entire empire from Delhi to Mabbar. D. They were tied to cavalry affordability.

Answer: C

Explanation: Empire-wide uniformity is precisely what the evidence does not securely prove.

Remedial MCQ 04

Question: Which statement best corrects a simplistic annexation narrative about the Deccan?

A. Every Deccan kingdom immediately became a fully administered Delhi province under Alauddin. B. The south had no significance for Delhi. C. Malik Kafur never crossed the Vindhya. D. Tribute, treasure, restored subordination and later selective annexation must be distinguished.

Answer: D

Explanation: Political relations differed sharply across Devagiri, Warangal, Dwarasamudra and Mabbar.

Remedial MCQ 05

Question: Which statement best corrects misuse of Barani?

A. Barani is indispensable but must be read as a late, moralising aristocratic source. B. Barani should be ignored because he is biased. C. Barani is useful only when repeated by later legend. D. Barani gives modern statistical series.

Answer: A

Explanation: Topic 04 depends on Barani, but never uncritically.

Remedial MCQ 06

Question: Which statement best corrects a Mughal-first misunderstanding?

A. Dag and chehra were first introduced by Akbar. B. Dag and chehra belong to Alauddin's military control and were later revived or systematised by others. C. Dag and chehra are only literary metaphors. D. Dag was a temple tax.

Answer: B

Explanation: Topic 07's corrected provenance controls this point.

Remedial MCQ 07

Question: Which statement best corrects a communal overreading of Alauddin's agrarian reforms?

A. The policy had no fiscal logic at all. B. The policy affected only Muslim nobles. C. The majority of cultivators were non-Muslim, but the policy's core logic was fiscal-military and anti-intermediary. D. The policy was designed only as a spiritual discipline.

Answer: C

Explanation: Demography and fiscal logic must both be kept in view.

Remedial MCQ 08

Question: Which statement best corrects the idea that controlled markets meant the end of trade?

A. Merchants were abolished from Delhi. B. Gujarat ceased to matter once the market system began. C. Banjaras were military officers only. D. State advances to traders and capital cloth inflow show regulated commerce, not commerce's disappearance.

Answer: D

Explanation: The system disciplined trade but depended on traders and carriers.

Remedial MCQ 09

Question: Which statement best corrects overstatement about Alai Darwaza?

A. It marks a mature scientific arch-and-dome phase, while the earlier surviving true arch belongs to Balban's tomb in this repository's sequence. B. It is the earliest surviving true arch in the assigned sequence. C. It has no relation to Khalji political ambition. D. It was built by Firuz Tughlaq.

Answer: A

Explanation: This is a classic elimination trap in Sultanate art questions.

Remedial MCQ 10

Question: Which statement best corrects a simplistic reading of the post-1316 collapse?

A. Every Khalji institution vanished instantly without residue. B. The rapid succession crisis revealed dependence on the ruler's personal coercive grip. C. Alauddin had already created a settled law of primogeniture. D. The Tughlaqs inherited nothing from the Khaljis.

Answer: B

Explanation: Institutions remained, but disciplined obedience and succession control broke down.

Remedial MCQ 11

Question: Which statement best corrects a false reading of Jalaluddin?

A. Jalaluddin's reign has no ideological significance at all. B. Jalaluddin was identical to Balban and Alauddin in political tone. C. Jalaluddin's reported support-based rhetoric helps explain why Alauddin's reversal looked so sharp. D. Jalaluddin ruled after Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq.

Answer: C

Explanation: The contrast is central to understanding the Khalji turn.

Remedial MCQ 12

Question: Which statement best corrects misuse of the term "Khalji revolution"?

A. It means universal social equality under the Khaljis. B. It means no continuity at all with the Mamluk order. C. It means a mass peasant uprising against the Turkish state. D. It means a substantial change in ruling-class access and composition within a continuing Delhi Sultanate framework.

Answer: D

Explanation: This is the safest definition for UPSC use.

Original solved Mains practice

10-mark Question 01

Question: Was the Khalji "revolution" more a reconfiguration of the ruling class than a social revolution? Discuss.
(Answer in 150 words)

Model solution:

Yes - in UPSC-safe usage the Khalji "revolution" is better understood as a **reconfiguration of elite access** than as a social revolution.

First, the local Satish Chandra evidence stresses that the rise of Jalaluddin Khalji ended the old Turkish monopoly of high office. Khaljis, Indian Muslims and other non-monopoly groups gained greater room in the ruling class. This is the strongest positive content of the phrase.

Second, the institutional structure remained recognisably Sultanate. Delhi stayed the centre, iqta logic continued, coercive monarchy persisted, and countryside hierarchy was not democratised. Alauddin's later regime was if anything harsher and more centralised than before.

Third, the population at large did not experience a social levelling revolution. Peasants still faced heavy extraction; nobles still dominated; military slavery and court hierarchy persisted.

Thus, the term is useful only when limited to **ruling-class composition and political access**. It becomes misleading when stretched into a mass social transformation.

Why this earns marks: It answers the directive directly, uses Satish Chandra's core insight, distinguishes elite from society and ends with a graded verdict.

10-mark Question 02

Question: How did Mongol pressure reshape Alauddin Khalji's state? Explain. (Answer in 150 words)

Model solution:

Mongol pressure pushed Alauddin Khalji toward a far more integrated **military-fiscal state**.

First, repeated crises - especially the 1299 Kili episode, the 1303 Siri-Delhi pressure and the 1305 Amroha battle - demonstrated that Delhi needed a large and ready cavalry. These events are securely anchored in the local OCR and PYQ routing.

Second, that army required affordable horses, reliable pay and fortified frontiers. Alauddin therefore strengthened the cavalry through **dagh** and **chehra**, repaired frontier forts and used a defended urban space at **Siri**.

Third, the fiscal base had to be deepened. Heavy revenue demand in the doab, cash realisation, grain movement and fixed prices all helped preserve the real value of soldier salaries.

Hence Mongol pressure did not produce only military response; it drove revenue reform, price regulation, surveillance and urban provisioning as well.

Why this earns marks: It converts frontier danger into an institutional chain rather than narrating battles in isolation.

15-mark Question 01

Question: Examine Alauddin Khalji's market regulations as an integrated military-fiscal system. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

Alauddin Khalji's market regulations are best explained not as welfare economics, but as a **Delhi-centred military-fiscal system**.

The starting point was strategic necessity. The Mongol attacks of the late 1290s and early 1300s convinced Alauddin that Delhi needed a large standing cavalry. Yet a large cavalry implied recurring expenditure on soldiers, horses and urban provisioning. The state therefore sought not merely treasure, but a durable mechanism for keeping the **real cost** of cavalry manageable.

This is where agrarian policy and market policy converged. In the upper doab, land revenue was pushed toward **half of the produce**, khalisa control was strengthened, measurement was used where supported, and cultivators were drawn into cash-linked grain sale. Grain then moved through monitored channels - banjaras, mandis and granaries - into Delhi. On the urban side, the grain mandi, the cloth sphere, and the horse-cattle-slave market were supervised by the **Shahna-i-Mandi** and linked to the wider regulatory authority of the **Diwan-i-Riyasat**.

The result was a chain: **revenue extraction -> supply control -> regulated prices -> affordable cash salaries -> military sustainability**. Barani's sample prices, and the reported cavalry pay scale of roughly 238 tankas annually, make sense within this chain.

Yet the system had limits. It depended on coercion, intelligence, capital-city concentration and ruler-driven discipline. Its strongest evidence is Delhi-centric, and it frayed quickly after Alauddin's death.

Thus, the regulations were integrated, innovative and effective in context, but narrow in geography and fragile in durability.

Why this earns marks: The answer uses the required mechanism, names the offices, links rural and urban policy, and finishes with scope and durability limits.

15-mark Question 02

Question: Distinguish the secure political-military evidence on Chittor from the later Padmavat tradition. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

The 1303 Chittor episode must be read through **source layering**.

The secure first layer is the political-military event. Near-contemporary courtly evidence, especially Amir Khusrau, anchors the siege, Alauddin's campaign context and the Khalji victory. The event fits the wider Rajputana strategy

after Gujarat and Ranthambore. Chittor mattered strategically, not only symbolically.

The second layer consists of conquest rhetoric. Khusrau's world is a court-praised world. Massacre motifs, triumphal language and the silence on uncomfortable details must be read as part of panegyric, not as transparent field-reporting.

The third layer is later literary memory. The **Padmavat** tradition associated with Malik Muhammad Jaisi is much later. It transforms the historical siege into a Sufi-inflected romance of beauty, desire, kingship and honour. Its narrative power is immense, but it is not a simple documentary source for 1303.

Hence, the historian must separate three things: the secure siege, the courtly rhetorical framing of conquest, and the later symbolic afterlife in Rajput and Indo-Persian memory. The error lies not in studying Padmavat, but in using it unfiltered as if it were contemporary evidence.

A good UPSC answer therefore says: **Chittor 1303 is historically secure; Padmavat is historically important as later memory, not as straightforward eyewitness archive.**

Why this earns marks: It uses named evidence, honours literary significance without surrendering chronology, and shows exactly how source criticism operates.

20-mark Question 01

Question: "Alauddin Khalji's price control was neither socialism nor mere anti-merchant tyranny, but a Delhi-centred military-fiscal experiment." Critically evaluate. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

The statement is broadly valid because Alauddin Khalji's price control makes the most sense as a **military-fiscal experiment** rooted in frontier pressure, noble politics and capital provisioning.

The evidence begins with the Mongol crisis. The Delhi-facing attacks of 1299, 1303 and 1305 showed that the Sultanate required a large cavalry under continuous readiness. A large cavalry, however, could not be sustained by windfall plunder alone. The state therefore needed to reduce the **real cost** of military maintenance.

This aim explains the interlocking structure of the reforms. In the upper doab, revenue demand rose sharply, direct khalisa control expanded, and measurement was used where supported. The grain thus drawn into state-visible channels was pushed into Delhi through banjaras, mandis and monitored sale. In the capital, staple grain, costly cloth and horse-cattle-slave markets were supervised through registers, the Shahna-i-Mandi and punitive enforcement. The reported price schedules preserved the value of cash salaries. That is why the system was linked to cavalry inspection through **dagh** and **chehra**, not separate from them.

Yet it would still be wrong to describe the system as benign consumer policy. It rested on coercion, heavy extraction, surveillance and severe penalties. Nor was it simply anti-merchant. Merchants, especially in cloth and grain supply, remained necessary; some even received state advances. Commerce was disciplined, not abolished.

Finally, the system's limits are decisive. It was Delhi-centred, expensive to police, mediated by Barani's moralising narrative, and highly ruler-dependent. Its rapid weakening after 1316 shows that coercive brilliance had outrun institutional durability.

Therefore, Alauddin's market control was a remarkable but bounded military-fiscal solution - neither modern socialism nor irrational persecution of trade.

Why this earns marks: It directly addresses the quotation, uses named evidence, shows mechanism, rejects two false binaries, and closes with a balanced critical verdict.

20-mark Question 02

Question: Assess the achievements and limits of the Khaljis in expansion, elite control and state formation. (Answer in 250 words)

Model solution:

The Khaljis mark one of the Sultanate's most consequential phases because they combined **elite reconfiguration**, **territorial expansion** and **deepened military-fiscal state formation**. But all three achievements carried serious limits.

Their first achievement was political. The accession of Jalaluddin Khalji ended the old Turkish monopoly of high office and widened the social base of the ruling class. This did not democratise society, but it changed who could rise within the Delhi political order. Alauddin deepened this by recruiting and promoting non-monopoly elements, including Malik Kafur and other non-Turkish figures.

Their second achievement was military and territorial. Gujarat, Ranthambore, Chittor and Malwa extended Delhi's reach in the west and centre. Deccan campaigns under Malik Kafur opened Devagiri, Warangal, Dwarasamudra and Mabar to Delhi's fiscal and political horizon. Yet the limits were sharp: Rajputana was not uniformly administered, and in the Deccan tribute, plunder and restored subordination often mattered more than direct rule.

Their third and greatest achievement was state formation under Alauddin. Confronting Mongol danger and noble conspiracy, he built a large cavalry, imposed **dagh** and **chehra**, tightened the doab revenue base, regulated markets and provisioned Delhi. This was a genuine military-fiscal innovation.

But the limits were built into the system. Heavy extraction, ruler-centred coercion, Delhi-focused enforcement and a fragile succession order meant that detailed controls did not long outlive Alauddin. Malik Kafur's interventions, Mubarak Shah's reversals and the fall to the Tughlaqs exposed that weakness.

Thus, the Khaljis achieved a major expansion and an extraordinary hardening of the Delhi state, but they did not solve the problem of durable, impersonal institutional continuity.

Why this earns marks: It is organised by the exact themes in the question, uses concrete examples in each theme, and ends with a graded verdict instead of a flat celebration.

Final consolidated register notes

01. Scope and framing

- Topic 04 = **1290-1320**: Jalaluddin, Alauddin, Kafur, Mubarak, Khusrau, Tughlaq takeover.
- Read the period as **source criticism + state capacity**, not as "socialism", "fanaticism" or a "perfect command economy".
- Core formula: **wider elite base + harsher coercive monarchy + Mongol pressure + Delhi-centred military-fiscal system**.
- Topic 03 owns full Mamluk institution-building; Topic 05 owns full Tughlaq aftermath; Topic 11 owns full art-history treatment.

02. Khalji revolution - safe definition

- Means **broadening of the ruling class**, ending old Turkish monopoly of high office.
- Does **not** mean mass social equality or peasant revolution.
- Khaljis were described in the concise source as of **mixed Turkish-Afghan origin**.
- Best verdict: **institutional continuity with elite-composition change**.

03. Jalaluddin and Alauddin

- Jalaluddin = comparatively conciliatory kingship; support-of-governed rhetoric; frontier commander.
- Alauddin = Kara/Devagiri loot + Jalaluddin's murder (1296) + gold-backed seizure of Delhi.
- Alauddin's legitimacy problem explains: confiscation, anti-noble ordinances, spies, market control logic.
- New converts after Gujarat loot rebellion punished harshly; Barani marks this as a grim precedent.

04. Mongol chronology - must know

- 1297-98 Jullundhar: Ulugh Khan victory.
- 1298 Siwistan: Zafar Khan success.
- 1299 Qutlugh Khwaja / Kili crisis.
- 1303 Targhi: Siri-Delhi pressure, defended camp and provisioning stress.
- 1305 Amroha: Malik Nayak defeats Ali Beg and Tartaq.
- PYQ trap: the first Mongol pressure on India did **not** begin under Jalaluddin Khalji.

05. Expansion and control language

- Gujarat = ports, bullion, horses -> stronger incorporation.
- Ranthambore (1301) = fort siege after Hamirdeva shelters Mongol fugitives.
- Chittor (1303) = secure siege-and-conquest event.
- Malwa = more direct control than many Rajput states.
- Devagiri under Ramachandra = restored subordinate ally first, later direct turn.
- Warangal / Dwarasamudra / Mabar = tribute, treasure, submission, raid; not all alike.

06. Chittor and Padmavat

- Near-contemporary Khusrau secures the military event.
- Later **Padmavat** = literary afterlife, not direct documentary report of 1303.
- Use phrase: "**secure siege, later romance, separate source layers.**"
- Never narrate mirror episode as straightforward contemporary fact.

07. Anti-rebellion monarchy

- Noble banquets and festivities curbed.
- Marriage alliances needed permission.
- Wine and intoxicants restricted.
- Wealth and grants confiscated.
- Spies/barids/munhiyan matter.
- Mechanism = **break funding + break solidarity + increase information + punish fast.**

08. Revenue reform engine

- Core zone = upper doab brought into **khalisa**.
- Demand reportedly around **half of produce**.
- Measurement used where supported.
- Khuts, muqaddams, chaudhurs targeted as privileged intermediaries.
- **Ghari** and **charai** noted in the source tradition.
- Best caution: strongest evidence is **core-zone**, not empire-wide.

09. Market-control engine

- Three named markets: grain, cloth, horse-slave-cattle.
- Analytical fourth cluster: wider controlled commodities.
- Shahna-i-Mandi + Diwan-i-Riyasat + merchant registers + banjaras + granaries + espionage.
- Sample prices may be cited only as **Barani-reported markers** with unit caution.
- Use the full chain: **revenue -> supply -> regulated prices -> salary value -> cavalry affordability.**

10. Limits, culture, significance and PYQ routes

- Delhi focus; high coercive cost; black-market risk; ruler dependence; quick post-1316 fraying.
- Alauddin's reason-of-state stance != modern secularism; Khalji state != pure theocracy.
- Architecture anchors: Siri, Alai Darwaza, unfinished Alai Minar, Hauz-i-Alai / later Hauz Khas.
- Source bank: **Barani** indispensable but late and normative; **Amir Khusrau** contemporary but panegyric; **Isami** useful but retrospective.
- Historical significance = **military-fiscal experimentation, stronger Delhi provisioning, Deccan opening, limits of personalised coercive institutions.**
- Verified PYQ routes for this package: 2022 Prelims Mongol chronology (direct); 2020 Persian literary sources (adjacent); 2023 Sultanate technology question (adjacent).